Dark Before the Dawn

Glen Rogers

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INTRODUCTION

The Farm

I was probably no older than ten when I first felt the silence of 4 a.m.

Not the kind that lingers when everyone else has gone to bed. This was different, the kind that greeted you in the dark, humming beneath the sound of a truck engine rolling down a gravel road. I'd ride with my Uncle John the half mile to the farm, headlights cutting through the dark like a lighthouse pulling us toward the work waiting ahead. There wasn't much talking, just a shared understanding of what needed to be done.

My brother, two years older, would be there too. He was the adventurer, always itching to be anywhere else, dreaming of games or sneaking off on some wild idea. Me? I was the rule follower. If Uncle John said bring in the cows, I was going to bring in the cows. It wasn't about liking it or not. It was about doing the job right.

We'd walk the pasture lane together, our boots and pants soaked from dew-covered alfalfa. That cold, wet slap against your legs was a rude awakening, but it came with a sense of

purpose. The cows weren't fast. Some mornings it felt like they were intentionally testing our patience. But over time, I started to notice patterns, tendencies that made the job smoother if you paid attention.

If you could get just one cow moving down the lane, the rest would usually follow. Or if you stomped your feet behind the herd like you were running, the cows would pick up the pace, thinking they were being chased. One of my favorite tricks came when I was around fifteen. I'd jump up and startle the cow. She hated it and would take off toward the barn in a hurry. The others, seeing her move, would follow suit. Herding became easier once you learned how to play the game.

There was always that one dumb one though. The straggler. Way behind. And if she was a heifer, you'd let her be. She would eventually come when she heard the feed motor fire up. But if she was a milker? You had to go back and get her, because she mattered. She had work to do. Just like me.

I remember the milk house, the hum of machines warming up, and the slow procession of cows moving in like clockwork. Somewhere out in the field, one of them would bellow, its call slicing through the still air. I can still smell the fresh-cut hay. I can still see the stars burning bright above me like they were trying to whisper something only I could hear.

Those mornings didn't feel like chores. They felt like initiation.

That's where my work ethic was carved: not from a motivational speech or a gym poster, but from cold boots, quiet stars, and a job that needed doing whether you felt like

it or not. I learned young that no one was going to do it for me. That if I wanted something done right, I had to be the one to do it, and I had to do it well.

The Edge

Fast forward to college, and I started hitting the gym early. Not because it was trendy, not because some influencer said to do it, but because I saw the edge.

When most guys were sleeping off the night before, I was grinding, sweating, growing. I found time most people swore they didn't have. I carved out space to get better before the world even got out of bed. That decision changed everything.

My freshman year, I made a friend who became more like a brother. He was one of the few on the football team who matched my intensity and shared the same passions: bodybuilding, the old *Incredible Hulk* TV show, Arnold Schwarzenegger, Franco Columbu, and anything strongman-related that played as reruns on cable TV. We were cut from the same cloth.

Back in high school, he was the guy I lined up against in football and tried to outthrow in the discus and shot put in track. In college, he was suddenly on my side, wearing the same colors. The first time we talked was during those grueling college two-a-days, morning and afternoon practices in the August heat. I walked up to his lunch table and asked, "Is your name Rudy?" He looked up, smiled, and said, "That's my nickname, but my real name's Matt." Then he asked, "Do you have a nickname?"

I shrugged and said, "Not really. I guess my sisters used to make fun of me and call me Buck because of my buck teeth as a kid."

Without missing a beat, he grinned and said, "Alright, I'll call you Buck."

From that moment on, we were inseparable. Training partners. Teammates. Brothers-in-iron. We did everything together.

After football season ended, we knew we had to keep lifting, but our schedules were chaos. Classes, jobs, late labs, and social stuff pulled everyone in different directions. The only consistent time we could both commit to was 5 a.m. So that's when we trained.

At first, it was just about logistics: getting it done before the day got in the way. But what started as necessity turned into something more powerful. I noticed that early morning workouts set me up for the entire day. I had more energy. I could relax at lunch without guilt. I had time for homework and recovery without feeling rushed. The pressure of the day didn't own me. I owned it.

I didn't know the science behind it back then, but I didn't need to. I knew how I felt. I knew I was sharper, calmer, stronger, not just in the weight room, but in the classroom and in life. That morning time became my anchor.

Those 5 a.m. sessions weren't just about building muscle. They were about building discipline, clarity, and confidence. While the rest of campus was sleeping, I was already stacking wins. That mindset stuck. And it laid the foundation for everything that came after.

The Evolution

Life keeps testing that foundation. Responsibility multiplies. Chaos finds you whether you're ready or not. And the question becomes: can the discipline you built in your twenties carry you through your thirties and forties? Can it survive marriage, kids, business ownership, and all the noise of real life?

In college, that fire didn't go out. I trained whenever I could. Mornings, afternoons, late nights. Sometimes with a team. Sometimes alone. It didn't matter. What mattered was that I showed up.

That became the throughline: no matter what else was going on, I found a way to make time for myself.

But life doesn't care about your plans. Setbacks come. Bodies break. People leave. Businesses struggle. And in those moments, you discover whether your discipline was real or just a hobby that depended on perfect conditions.

Movement is more than fitness. It's how I've always come back to myself. When life gets loud, movement is my silence. When things fall apart, movement is the first step toward putting them back together.

This book is about that idea. Not perfection. Not motivation. Movement as identity, built in the dark, before the world wakes up.

Part 1: The Call

Before the World Wakes

CHAPTER 1

Bottles and Barbells

The Natural Progression

I've always been an early riser. Not because it was trendy or because someone told me to be. It just made sense.

Even as a kid, I realized the earlier I got to work out, the more time I had for everything else: household chores, work, school, football, or just hanging out with friends. It wasn't long before I started chasing that extra edge. If I got stronger, I played better. If I played better, I got noticed. If I got noticed, more doors opened. I wasn't chasing aesthetics. I was chasing power, speed, and impact. I wanted to run faster, jump higher, and hit harder, and I saw firsthand how lifting made that possible.

It became my thing. My identity. My anchor.

By high school, lifting wasn't just a part of my routine; it was the routine. Other kids started tagging along in the weight room. Coaches saw the effort and started opening it up for me between classes. I didn't need much, just a squat rack, a barbell, and a goal. That was enough. Looking back, that's where discipline started for me. No one made me do it. No

one was watching most of the time. I did it because it made me feel capable. Strong. Clear.

High school was easy. We'd listen to loud music and not have any worries. We lifted for girls and sports, and it became our sanctuary time because we were the strongest kids in school coming into our senior year. The only stress we had was figuring out what we wanted to do with the rest of our lives. At seventeen and eighteen, not much thought really went into that. I knew I was going to UW-Eau Claire. My buddy knew he was going into the trades. We'd figure it out when we got there. No real worries, just school and lifting.

The Early Grind

After receiving my undergraduate degree at UW-Eau Claire, I went to graduate school at North Dakota State University as a graduate assistant. I was working 12 hours a day Monday through Friday, then heading to school three nights a week until 9 p.m. And still, I'd train in the mornings. Lift weights at 4 a.m., quick shower, then roll right into our first athlete group of the day. It didn't matter how packed the day was. That time before the sun came up? That was mine. It was quiet. Focused. Intentional.

When I took my first job out of grad school, it started at 6 a.m., which to me felt late. I was already up. Already moving. Already checked off the box that most people put off. I remember thinking, "This is the life. I'll never work earlier than 6 a.m." Funny how that turned out.

Then I opened my own gym. And at first, I stuck to it: no clients earlier than 6 a.m. That was the rule. But clients talk. Word spreads. My 6 a.m. clients started noticing the lights

were already on when they pulled up. Some would walk in and see me already sweaty, mid-set, music blaring. That's when the questions started. "Wait, what time do you get here?" Some asked if they could start earlier. "Since you're already here..."

And here's the thing: I love helping people. But I also love my solitude. Lifting, for me, is more than a workout. It's meditation. It's therapy. It's the one place where I can breathe without someone needing something from me.

But I don't like confrontation. So as long as I could make the clients happy and still get my workout done, I'd gladly get up earlier. So I started training at 5 a.m. to avoid the crowd. Then 4:30. Eventually, 4 a.m. became my time. No interruptions. No small talk. Just the barbell and my thoughts.

Until that didn't work either.

When Sacred Time Gets Hijacked

In the first couple years of owning my gym, I tried working out in the afternoons. As a personal trainer, you're locked into what I call a "forever split shift." You work before other people start their day, and then again after school or work lets out. The middle of the day was naturally my pocket to train.

And it worked...for a while.

But I couldn't do everything. I couldn't be a gym owner trying to work out and take calls from potential clients. I always felt rushed, trying to get it all done. The first five years of owning my business, I was still thinking s*hould I own my own business or get a real job?* It was a stressful time, and I didn't

know the outcome. The only thing keeping me sane was my training.

Then came the interruptions that broke me. Clients showing up unannounced. Clients coming in fifteen minutes late and expecting a full hour, cutting into my next paying customer's time. I had enough and had to stop training a client because it just led to constant frustration.

But the worst part? My workout time was my meditation time, and life's stresses were crushing down on me. I had a gym buddy who'd started training with me because he wanted to do something else with his life. Then he took advantage of the situation, by poaching my clients, to eventually open his own gym. I had an opportunity to train in-home clients and create more money to pay bills during those less busy training times. He positioned himself as "helping" by taking the other clients I had at those times. In the service industry, it's about the person, so they got used to him. I felt betrayed.

I reverted to the old farm mentality: suppress everything, power through, don't talk about it. Just put your head down and work. But I couldn't even do that anymore. My one-hour training block became prime time for interruptions: calls from potential clients, questions about pricing, people needing to get signed up. Even when I wasn't on the phone, it was always running in the back of my mind. Add in the relationship stress of wanting a girlfriend, having one, not having one, or having one who lived an hour away with no time to see her often further complicated life. I was being pulled apart in every direction except the one that mattered: focusing on my training session. I wasn't lifting. I was

grinding. I lost my rhythm. I was just chasing the clock. And I hated it.

The one thing that had always grounded me was starting to slip. When something that used to be sacred becomes just another item on your to-do list, something has to change.

Return to Self

That's when I reclaimed the mornings. No one needing anything from me. Just the sound of the iron plates clanging before the sun comes up and the feeling of being completely in control. The weight doesn't care about your schedule. It doesn't ask questions. It demands presence.

There's something powerful about being the only one awake while the rest of the world sleeps. It's like you're getting a head start not just on the day, but on becoming who you're meant to be.

And eventually, I had to lay down the law with my early clients. No earlier than 5 a.m. If that didn't work, they could go somewhere else. This hour was mine.

Then Came the Bottles

After our first child, Brooklyn, was born, I had my morning routine down to a science. Even with Brooklyn in the picture, I didn't skip a beat. In fact, she became even more of a reason to stay sharp. I wanted to be the dad who could still sprint, squat, and be mobile. I wanted her to see what discipline looked like, not because I told her, but because she watched it.

My wife and I found a rhythm. She'd take the 3 a.m. feeding while I grabbed one last chunk of sleep. Most mornings, she

was making her way back into bed just as I was getting up for the day. I'd kiss her on the forehead, quietly change into my gym gear, and slip out the door. It wasn't easy, but it worked.

Then life flipped. Twins.

By seven months pregnant, my wife couldn't handle the chaos anymore. Brooklyn, only thirteen months old, was strong as an ox and didn't want to go to bed without a fight. My wife, already worn down and hurting, needed me as a partner. So I took over bedtime duties.

When the twins were born, things got harder. Much harder. Three kids under two, all needing something different at all times. It was exhausting.

At first, I tried to sleep through those early cries. But lying in bed while she made bottles and handled crying babies didn't sit right. After all, we were partners and I needed to help. It's hard to fire up in the early morning with that kind of overwhelm. I decided if someone was going to own the mornings, it might as well be me.

The 2:45 a.m. Shift

I set the alarm for 2:45 a.m.

I'm an "if you're five minutes early, you're ten minutes late" type of person, so I'd get up early and wait for the twins to make a peep. Babies are pretty regular once you start seeing their patterns. I'd prep the bottles, tiptoe into the nursery, and feed them before they fully woke. Keep them on the same schedule, or you suffer. Feed them both at once and pray they would drift back to sleep.

If I timed it right, I'd finish by 3:30 a.m. The house would be quiet again. And I'd just be sitting there, thinking: *Well... this is when I usually wake up anyway. Might as well go lift.*

My wife was all for it. It just became a habit. She doesn't say much about it because those early days were stressful for all of us. With babies, there's no easy version. It's all hard work, just different kinds of hard. I didn't want to feel like a piece of crap lying in bed while my wife did everything, and I couldn't sleep anyway.

Now when people ask about my 2:45 a.m. routine, my wife usually says, "I don't know how he does it." But in the same breath, when she's frustrated at me about something, she'll say, "All you do is go to bed at 9 p.m. and we can't even watch a movie together." Those always make me laugh because those are the moments where you're grabbing at straws, trying to defend your stance in a dumb fight. My wife and I have plenty of dumb "nothing fights." We are just like other couples. We love each other but conflict occurs and is normal in any healthy relationship.

The Evolution

This became the new rhythm. 2:45 a.m. alarm. Feed the twins. Hit the gym by 4 a.m.

It wasn't about chasing PRs anymore. It was about survival, sanity, and holding onto a piece of myself. That sacred hour before the rest of the world stirred, even if it came after wiping spit-up and changing diapers, was still mine.

Some mornings were magic. Others? Just muscle memory and stubbornness. But every day, I showed up.

Because I wasn't just lifting weights anymore. I was lifting the weight of responsibility, of legacy, of love. And in those quiet moments between feeding babies and moving iron, I realized something: this time in the morning isn't just a workout. It's a promise I keep to myself.

When are you going to find that time for yourself? Maybe it's early mornings like me. Maybe it's something else. But if you ever say you need to go on a diet, lose weight, get organized, or make more money, getting a morning routine will help you fire on all cylinders.

Set out one thing you can do each morning before you start your day. See what you can accomplish when you take control of just one thing before the rest of the world wakes up and starts making demands.

Because if you don't claim a piece of your day, the rest of the world will.

CHAPTER 2

The Accidental Discipline

Duty Before Choice

I never set out to become a morning person.

In fact, those early mornings felt more like punishment than purpose. They weren't structured by intention or ambition, but by the rhythms of rural life and a household that ran on grit, not grace. There was no motivational poster or success guru pulling me out of bed, just the sound of footsteps on old wooden floors and the echo of a familiar voice:

"Up and at 'em, boys. Put your work boots on."

It didn't matter if it was Saturday or summer, raining or freezing. There was always work to do. My brother and I learned early on that sleeping in meant missing out, not just on cartoons, but on your role in something bigger.

We weren't milking cows or feeding calves because we wanted to. We did it because the animals depended on us. And in the quiet of those dawn hours, while pouring feed or wiping the frost off a fence post, I began to sense something

I didn't yet have the words for: a rhythm, a grounding, a reward in the repetition.

Every morning, we were greeted by the same sky, but never the same sunrise. "Red sky in the morning, sailors take warning. Red sky at night, sailor's delight." We said it like gospel, even though we had nothing to do with sailing. We just understood that the world had signs, and if you paid attention long enough, it would teach you things.

At the time, I didn't know what "discipline" was. I just knew if I got up late for school, the whole day felt off, like I was playing catch-up before the game even started. I didn't know that doing chores when you're tired is training. That showing up unmotivated is still showing up. That repetition without reward is where real growth happens.

Looking back now, I can see it clearly. Those early mornings were my bamboo roots. You've probably heard the analogy: the Chinese bamboo tree takes five years to grow. Five years of nothing visible happening above the surface. But beneath the soil, it's developing a massive root system. And then, in the fifth year, it suddenly sprouts, growing up to 90 feet in just six weeks.

That's what early mornings did for me. I didn't love them at first. I fought them. But somewhere along the way, without realizing it, they became mine. Not because I had to, but because I wanted to.

The routines that started out of duty became rituals I now rely on. The discipline I once resented is the very foundation I stand on today. And that's the beauty of accidental

discipline: it sneaks up on you. What starts as survival slowly becomes sacred.

When Identity Gets Complicated

But understanding who you're becoming isn't always straightforward. Sometimes you have to learn what you're not before you discover what you are.

I learned this the hard way on a seventh-grade basketball court.

I'd been riding the bench all season, happily, to be honest. I was with my boys, laughing, part of the team. That was enough for me. But with about a minute left in the game, the coach looked down the bench and said, "Glen, you want to get in there?"

I looked across the gym, saw my dad in the stands (his voice boomed louder than anyone else's in that small gym), and said, "No."

Not because I was scared of playing. But because I already knew what was coming. I'd been in games before where my coach would tell me to do one thing and my dad would yell something different from the stands. I'd listen to my dad because I was going home with him. Then came the car ride, a play-by-play breakdown of my two minutes on the court, every mistake highlighted, every missed opportunity dissected.

In three years of basketball, I scored eleven points total and rarely played. But I relived every second of those limited minutes on the way home after each game. It dug in deeper each time.

That "No" was me realizing something important: I was only getting a pity placement in the game, and I was okay with that. I was happy watching some of the other athletes excel. I didn't want to be embarrassed again.

But that moment taught me something about identity that would shape how I coach kids decades later: you cannot over-coach anyone. I should restate that: you cannot over-coach anyone willing to learn. You need to pick one thing and make sure they can do it well, then pick something else. And you better give them praise for accomplishing even the little things, because not all kids are born with talent. Through hard work, effort, and consistency, they become talented.

Identity Isn't an Outcome. It's Who You Become

Years later, I saw this principle play out perfectly with one of my athletes.

When Sam Vargas first walked into my gym, he was twelve years old, a little scrawny, sports-tech glasses on, carrying a baseball glove. Like a lot of kids, he thought his future was in baseball. He trained hard, worked on his strength, built speed for stealing bases and running down line drives. His outcome goal was simple: be a better baseball player.

But something happened along the way. The more Sam trained, the more he discovered something different about himself. He was fast. Not just quick-for-baseball fast. Fast-fast. He gave track a try, and suddenly the story started to shift.

Sam went from chasing a goal ("I want to be a better baseball player") to living out an identity ("I'm a sprinter"). And once that switch flipped, everything changed. He didn't have to

force himself to train like a sprinter because he was a sprinter. Every rep in the gym, every sprint on the track wasn't just practice. It was proof.

Now, a few years later, Sam isn't "a kid who's trying track." He's one of the fastest in the state, with more than five records at Arrowhead High School, and a two-time All-American as a freshman at UW-Whitewater in the 100m and 200m.

That's the power of identity-based habits. Most people start with outcomes: "I want to run a marathon." "I want to lose 20 pounds." "I want to get stronger." Those goals can get you moving, but they don't keep you steady when life gets difficult. Goals live on paper. Identity lives inside you.

Sam didn't become an All-American because he wrote down "run faster" on a goal sheet. He became an All-American because every practice, every weight session, every recovery routine stacked up into proof of who he was becoming. Not "a kid chasing a goal." A sprinter.

Finding What You're Actually Good At

For me, that discovery came through elimination. I wasn't a basketball player, at least not a shooter. But when kids ask me about playing basketball now, I don't talk about those eleven points. I talk about dunking. Because that's what I could do. I was throwing down full dunks by freshman year. That was my thing.

The discipline I'd built on the farm: showing up, doing the work, pushing through discomfort, transferred to the weight room. I fell in love with weights and movement. My arms

didn't feel right for shooting a basketball, but they felt perfect wrapped around a barbell.

That shift from "having to" to "choosing to" happened gradually. What started as duty, early morning wake-ups, missing cartoons, bringing cows in, became routine. And over time, that routine shaped my identity. I wasn't just someone who got up early. I became someone who leads the day instead of reacting to it. Someone who finishes strong because I start with purpose.

The Shift Most People Miss

We think discipline is about pushing harder. Grinding more. Forcing it. But real, lasting discipline, the kind that holds up when no one's watching, isn't fueled by motivation. It's fueled by identity.

Once your identity takes root, when you begin to act from who you are, not just what you want, people start to notice. They see something in you. A steadiness. A grit. A kind of unspoken credibility. You become the person others look to, not because you're the loudest in the room, but because you're already doing the work when no one's watching.

That's leadership. Not a title. Not a rank. Just reputation earned through consistency.

The routines that started on the farm weren't glamorous. But honest, real, and taught me life lessons: you eat the elephant one bite at a time. You face a plate full of frogs by starting with the biggest one first. And before long, you look in the mirror and realize you've become someone who doesn't wait for motivation. You just show up. Because that's who you are now.

The Days Are Long, But the Years Are Fast

Here's the lesson I wish someone had told me at twelve, sitting on that basketball bench: you need to do this for yourself. Not for your parents, not for your coaches, not for anyone else's approval. For you.

It's the old cliché about little kids. The days are long, but the years are short. You need to start building who you want to become now, because before you know it, Father Time is knocking on your door.

Growing up, I watched everyone around me work hard for their goals, but also for the love of what they did. It wasn't just because they had to. It was because they wanted to. Everyone has bad days when you feel like quitting, when the grass looks greener on the other side. But it doesn't work like that.

The discipline I learned accidentally on those cold farm mornings became the foundation for everything that followed. Not because someone forced it on me, but because I discovered something valuable in the repetition, the rhythm, the simple act of showing up when showing up was required.

That's accidental discipline becoming intentional identity. And once you make that shift, everything changes.

CHAPTER 3

Redefining "Rest"

When Rest Meant Weakness

There was a time I thought rest was for the weak. I'd spend years believing that, until the quiet, early mornings of 2020, when deep breathing and a cold basement floor began to teach me something different.

I grew up in the era of Ripped Fuel and Stacker 2. We were a society addicted to going 1,000% and never stopping. Early mornings, late nights, caffeine, adrenaline: whatever it took to keep the machine running. I was built that way. Programmed early. Mornings started with farm chores, followed by a quick fifteen-minute nap after breakfast, then back out in the blazing heat for round two. That was my version of rest: get in, get out, and get moving again.

But every moment in life teaches you something, especially when you're too stubborn to slow down.

I remember lifting at 4 a.m., working all day, then staying up all night learning Visual Basic and my new love for coding to help build nutrition programs for clients, only to try lifting

again at 4 a.m. the next day. It was one of the worst workouts of my life. My body was toast. Not because I lacked motivation, but because I had zero recovery. You can't out-hustle biology. My strength was gone. My energy was shot. My mind wasn't sharp. There was no rest. Just ambition running on fumes.

The Crash Course

Years later, when work started coming down on me from all directions (clients, bills, business decisions, the weight of being responsible for everything), I found myself reaching for old habits. Five beers on a Friday night turned into six on Saturday. What started as stress relief became another source of stress. I'd wake up puffy, feeling like crap, trying to drudge through the day like I was back in college.

I couldn't do it anymore. I needed a change.

But the change didn't come from willpower or motivation. It came from an unexpected place: a basement floor and the simple act of stretching.

The Basement Discovery

When the pandemic hit in 2020, our twins were born in May. I was spending more time at home, and for the first time in years, I had a chance to slow down just enough to try something I'd always dismissed: yoga.

I'd always wanted to do the splits for martial arts, something I'd dreamed about since watching kung fu movies as a kid. I started getting up Sunday mornings before Brooklyn was awake, working on flexibility and dealing with nagging injuries from years of heavy lifting.

My wife gave me some grief about it. She said I'd quit within a month. Instead of arguing, I put my hard hat on and went to work. I proved her wrong for over a year.

I took my yoga routine down to our newly renovated basement. A couple years earlier, it had been a dungeon: musty, damp, with thin carpet glued to half the floor and cheap paneling on the walls. My wife and I had torn all that out, put in insulated walls, cushiony carpet, and a gas fireplace. I'd built the mantle myself, a faux wood beam with perfect angles that looked like a real 6x6 log. The light gray walls bounced color off the floors, and the open ceiling spray-painted black created an endless cover that seemed to reach upward.

One specific morning stands out. I was stretching on the same mat that Brooklyn and I had been playing with toy cars on the day before. Looking up at the fireplace I'd built with my own hands, I felt something I hadn't felt in months: peace. Contentment. I was thinking about the Bible verse we had hanging above Brooklyn's crib, Jeremiah 1:5: "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, before you were born I set you apart." That sense of being exactly where I was supposed to be.

It was the first time in years that "rest" didn't feel like quitting. It felt like preparing.

Learning from Grandma

My grandmother taught me about this kind of rest without ever using the word. She never sat still, always in the kitchen making food for the family, or outside weeding her garden. But watching her, you could see it wasn't work. It was her

passion. Her "me time." She poured her heart and soul into everything she did, and we all saw the beauty that came from it.

She's 93 now, still lifting three-pound dumbbells in her wheelchair, still the heartbeat of our family. That kind of energy passed down to my mom, who can be cooking on the stove while changing playdough stations for the kids and setting up a cookie-baking spot on the counter. She's always playing offense, redirecting issues before they become problems. At the heart of both women is love. They love what they do, and when your passion spills over, others are attracted to it.

That's what I was missing. I thought rest meant stopping. But watching them, I realized rest could be active. It could be purposeful. It could be preparation for serving others better.

The Burnout Nobody Talks About

There's a kind of burnout no one warns you about. Not the kind where your body gives out, but the kind where your purpose is crushing you like a weight on your chest. Where even the things you used to love start to wear you down. Where the gym (your sacred space) feels like one more item on a to-do list you're drowning under.

I'd been there. I wasn't overtrained. I was under-recovered. Physically present but emotionally checked out. Still hitting the sets, still getting the work in, but it wasn't giving anything back. I was just going through the motions, trying to clear my head, but my safe space felt occupied by negative feedback loops.

That's when I realized that I needed to get up earlier to have more energy for my workouts. I needed to focus back on my goals and what I wanted to do, not live according to the circumstances that others created. My goals were my family and my wife. For me to be the best husband and father I could be, I had to get my own mind right first.

Redefining Rest

The kind of rest I'm talking about isn't sleeping in until noon or vegging out on the couch. It's active. Intentional. Rest that renews you for what's coming next.

For me, rest is movement with intention. Stretching without a clock. Sipping hot black coffee in complete silence. Sitting in my gym before it opens, just breathing in the space I built. That's what grounds me.

Some people meditate cross-legged on a cushion. I meditate driving to my gym at 3 a.m., sometimes with music, most of the time not. The moon is bright. The stars are overhead. My headlights stir the creatures around me. That's my sanctuary. That's my recharge.

Rest is personal. But it must be pursued. It won't fall in your lap. It has to be carved out, protected, practiced.

The Morning Reset

I wake up early because each day is a blank slate. Maybe you've got bills to pay, kids to drop off at two different schools, or a report your supervisor needs by noon. That stuff is coming. But not yet. Right now, when the world still sleeps, is your reset.

That's the gift of early mornings: the world hasn't made its demands yet. If I start work at 5 a.m., I train before that. If I start at 8, I train before the kids are up. Either way, it's dark. But that's where I find the light.

Real rest doesn't take you away from life. It brings you back to it. Back to presence. Back to clarity. Back to purpose. Because when you're truly rested, you see more. The people around you. The mission in front of you. The moments that actually matter.

This isn't about doing less. It's about doing what matters more. Rest isn't retreating. It's reloading. It's that breath between rounds. That calm before the next swing of the axe. It's not the absence of effort. It's the rhythm that makes effort sustainable.

So take the morning. Take the breath. Take the space to hear yourself again. Because your comeback doesn't begin when you start grinding. It begins when you take time to start listening.

CHAPTER 4

Early Isn't Easy – But It's Yours

The First Hour Advantage

When life feels out of control, we need to find something we can control. For some, it's diet. For others, it's movement, spiritual grounding, or even that sacred first sip of coffee in the dark before the world wakes up. There's a strange calm in those early hours: a kind of quiet authority. There's order. There's direction. There's ownership.

But most of us start our days in reverse. We wake to the sound of chaos (the kid puking, the dog having an accident, the toilet overflowing). We're not stepping into the ring with a plan; we're already on our heels, reacting, flinching, flailing. You never want to fight from your heels. That's a losing stance.

And it's exactly how most of us live. We say we work best under pressure. We wait until the fire's raging to act. Deadlines light the fuse and we call it "motivation." But it's not motivation. It's anxiety. And those decisions made in the

middle of morning madness? They're rarely thoughtful, rarely grounded.

Control the first hour, and you reclaim the wheel. You start from peace, not panic.

Building the Foundation

This started early for me. Mornings in our house began very similarly when I was growing up. My mom would set out my clothes the night before, and after getting out of bed, we had to make the bed to my retired military dad's specifications. After a few times of making it over and over again, I learned to tuck the sheets in so tight I could climb in through the top so I wouldn't pull them loose the next morning. It was like a cocoon, and I would slither out of the top and straighten the comforter to a crisp edge.

Sliding into the clothes my mom laid out, I would brush my teeth and continue my day. Everything was done, and I had already won three micro-battles. That foundation of discipline carried into adulthood. I still set my clothes out the night before. Now, with a wife, I avoid any noise that could wake her. I set my clothes in the bathroom, quietly close the door, brush my teeth, and get dressed.

Those small wins stack up. It's like prepping meals for a bodybuilding show. Once everything is planned out, you don't have to waste energy thinking about what to eat. Your mind is freed up to focus on the real work, the meaningful conversations, the actual tasks that move life forward.

The 3 a.m. Advantage

I wake up at 3 a.m. each day. Sometimes, my daughter wakes around 2:30 to go potty. If she doesn't wake us, I gently wake her up to make sure she goes. After tucking her back in, I head downstairs and grab a high-protein breakfast like Greek yogurt with a scoop of whey. Our 40-pound Goldendoodle often joins me, stomping like a freight train down the stairs. Before I leave, I let him back upstairs to avoid whining, and, of course, he hops on the bed with his usual huffs and puffs. So much for being quiet.

On weekends, when I wrote my first book *Strong Again*, I'd complete my routine and head to the basement to write. That gave me two and a half solid hours of uninterrupted reflection and creativity. Looking back on your own life, writing about where you've been and where you're going, checks your ego big time. That quiet time in the basement, just me and my thoughts, truly helped me realize who I was.

Then comes the drive to the gym at 3:15 a.m. No traffic. No rush. Just me, the deer, and the quiet road. I'm not worrying about the day ahead. I'm just being in the moment. That sense of accomplishment hits before most people open their eyes. I already put in a full day's work by the time everyone else wakes up.

That feeling? "This time is MINE."

By 6 a.m., when my son typically woke up, I felt like I had already won the day. If he slept longer, I would intentionally wait in my chair, listening for the first sign of footsteps. When he woke, I would help him out of his pajamas, brush

his teeth, and get him dressed, ready for Spot It, puzzles, or Paw Patrol. I was present. Not rushed. Not stressed. Ready.

When You Don't Own Your Hour

Then there was Father's Day 2024. I decided to sleep in. We planned to go to church as a family. But the kids woke up and went downstairs on their own. My wife handles mornings differently. She lets the kids play in their pajamas and brushes their teeth later. It's not wrong, just different. But to me, it felt like chaos. Pajamas in the kitchen. Toothbrushes on the stairs.

I thought it would be a peaceful morning. Instead, it was a stressful mess. We fought about the kids being late, not being dressed, the noise, the tension. I was trying to create order out of the chaos, but to my wife, it seemed like I was telling her she wasn't doing a good job. Since I'm not home every morning with the kids, my attempts at structure felt like judgment. Her look said it all. She thought I was criticizing her when I was just trying to herd cats.

This went on for weeks. Eventually, I realized the problem wasn't her approach or mine. The problem was that I'd given up my anchor. Without that first hour to center myself, I was starting the day reactive instead of responsive. Frustrated instead of grounded.

The Cost of Juggling Too Much

It shows up in smaller ways too. One morning, I tried to cook eggs while getting Liam ready. I left the stove to help him, frustrated that he wasn't moving fast enough, even though he had just woken up and I had been up for hours.

The eggs were burning, I was juggling too much, and my patience snapped.

It reminded me of working with my dad on cars. I was the flashlight holder. He'd get frustrated because I couldn't hold it perfectly, and I'd end up resenting the garage. Same thing here. I was trying to cook and parent at the same time without enough margin.

That's what happens when you don't own your first hour. You're already behind before the day starts. Everything feels urgent. Every task feels like it's competing for the same limited space. You lose your center, and everyone around you feels it.

Early Anchors

The moment I feel the power of ownership most is on Sunday mornings, getting ready for church. When I get up early, follow my routine, and anchor myself before the rest of the house wakes up, everything shifts. There's no scrambling. No yelling. Just quiet readiness.

When the kids start to wake up, I don't have to rush. I'm already steady. Each child moves through their own early anchor: bathroom, teeth brushed, hair done, dressed for the day, bed made. Then we head downstairs. It's not "Let's get ready for church." It's "Let's get ready for our day."

If we skip this rhythm, it shows. We're rushing. Shoes are lost. Voices are raised. Everyone's frustrated. But when we're anchored? The whole house breathes easier. The kids are more focused. The vibe is calm. And the parents are happier, too.

To me, mornings are like quiet time for adults. No kid wants to go to their room for quiet time. But nine times out of ten, they nap or play peacefully with no distractions, no noise. Getting up early is the same. You don't always want to. You might hit snooze or lie there negotiating. But if you follow through, nine times out of ten, you're productive. You've already won something before most people open their eyes.

It's About Ownership, Not Motivation

People say I'm disciplined. I don't see it that way. I see it as ownership.

I don't get up early just to train. I don't write in the dark because I'm some hyper productive machine. I do it because I'm investing in my future self. Because I want my kids to remember me not as the tired, reactive version of myself, but the man who showed up. Physically strong. Mentally clear. Spiritually grounded.

On the days I don't feel like it, it's not motivation that moves me. It's purpose. I don't write for likes or sales. I write for legacy. For my kids. For their kids. One day, they'll hold these pages and feel the strength behind the words.

Because this isn't about checking boxes. It's about becoming someone who matters to yourself, to your people, and to the future you may never meet.

The Legacy You're Building

Early isn't easy. Nobody pretends it is. The alarm at 3 a.m. doesn't get more pleasant over time. The cold floor doesn't warm up. The quiet house doesn't become less lonely.

But it's yours. That first hour belongs to you in a way nothing else will for the rest of the day. Your boss will own your work hours. Your kids will own your evening. Your spouse will own your attention. The world will make its demands.

But that first hour? That's when you get to choose who you'll be today.

Every morning you own that hour, you're not just building discipline. You're building a legacy. You're showing your kids what it looks like to take control before life takes control of you. You're modeling what it means to prepare instead of react, to lead instead of follow, to show up instead of hope things work out.

The way you own your morning is the way your kids will own their lives. That's not pressure. That's purpose. And it starts in the dark, before the world wakes up, with the simple choice to claim what's yours.

Early isn't easy. But it's yours. And if you can own your first hour, you can own the rest of your day, but more importantly, the rest of your life.

CHAPTER 5

The Myth of Balance

Why Balance Fails

Forget balance. Build rhythm.

You've probably been told to "find balance." Balance your work and home life. Balance your diet. Balance your training. Hell, balance your emotions.

But let me ask you something: how's that working out for you?

Because every time I tried chasing balance, I ended up exhausted, frustrated, and falling behind in the very things I cared about most. The harder I tried to balance everything, the more I felt like I was failing at everything. Like spinning plates while standing on a BOSU ball during an earthquake.

Here's the truth: balance is a myth.

It's Pinterest wisdom. Instagram therapy. It sounds noble, but it's built on the lie that life can be perfectly divided into equal parts. That you can give 100% to your job, 100% to your kids, 100% to your spouse, your training, your faith, your

business, your inbox... and still have something left for yourself.

But life doesn't care about your math.

Real life comes in waves. Some weeks you're the best dad on the planet, but your business feels like it's slipping. Other weeks, you're closing deals, hitting PRs, and forgetting to pack your kid's lunch. You'll crush a deadline but miss a date night. You'll feel strong one day and sleep-deprived the next.

And if you measure your worth by how "balanced" it all feels, you'll always feel like you're losing.

That's why Tim Grover, trainer to Michael Jordan and author of *Relentless*, cuts through the noise: winning wants all of you. At the highest levels, something has to give. That's not failure. That's focus.

As Grover explains, *Cleaners* (the elite performers who dominate consistently) don't chase balance. They sacrifice the rest to go all-in on what matters most in that season.

The Shift You Need

You don't need balance. You need rhythm.

Balance demands symmetry, that yoga-pose mindset where Work = Gym = Home = Everything equals happiness.

Rhythm accepts seasons: weeks or months where one part of your life gets louder, and others quiet down. And that's how life actually flows.

Rhythm is about intentional flow. It's knowing when to push, when to pause, and when to pivot. It's training hard Monday, scaling back Thursday, resting Saturday, all on purpose. It's

being all in at work when you're there, and all in at home when you're not. It's choosing presence over perfection.

Balance says everything matters equally. Rhythm says everything has its time.

Learning Rhythm Early

I learned this before I knew what to call it. My grandparents never talked about "work-life balance." There was just work. And more work. But they weren't bitter about it.

My grandfather poured concrete all day, then came home to work the farm. My grandmother was up before the sun baking, gardening, cooking everything from scratch. She raised eight kids and now had grandkids under her roof. I never saw her sit down.

But here's what I noticed: they weren't trying to do everything at once. They had seasons. Concrete season. Planting season. Harvest season. Canning season. Each had its rhythm, its intensity, its focus.

That idea of "focus and go all in" stuck with me. Even when I played as a kid, I played all day. No half-measures. That was rhythm.

When I Tried Balance

But like everyone else, I got sold the balance myth in my twenties. I thought I could work on my uncle's dairy farm, run a second job at a go-kart track, maintain a relationship an hour away, and still perform at my peak.

For five days while my uncle was on vacation, I tried to do it all. Thirteen hours of sleep in five days. I bragged about it like a badge of honor. My body treated it like a death sentence.

The crash happened less than a mile from home. That's where most accidents happen, right? I was running on fumes, and my body finally shut down. The next thing I remember is pain, screaming, glass, and the hydraulic sound of metal being torn apart to get me out.

That moment shattered more than glass and bone. It shattered my illusion of balance.

What I was really doing was juggling chaos: running on fumes, living in denial, and calling it discipline. Balance isn't about doing everything at once. It's about knowing what can wait and what can't.

Finding My Rhythm

My real breakthrough came in college when I decided to compete in bodybuilding. Not because I felt balanced, but because I was finally ready to go all-in on something that mattered.

I grabbed six cheap containers and wrote meal times on them with a Sharpie:

5:00 a.m. – Egg whites and broccoli

6:00 a.m. – Post-workout protein shake

9:00 a.m. – Chicken breast and cauliflower

12:00 p.m. – Another shake

2:00 p.m. – Chicken again

6:00 p.m. – Last meal before night class

9:00 p.m. – Prep it all again for tomorrow

Twelve weeks. No distractions. No exceptions. Show day came. I'd earned that stage.

Was that balance? Hell no. That was discipline. That was rhythm. That was knowing the season I was in and owning it completely.

Rhythm in Real Life

Now, as a father, gym owner, coach, husband, and writer, I've stopped measuring my life by symmetry. Life isn't a scale. It's a song. And sometimes, the tempo changes.

Just like a boxer in the ring, bouncing front to back, side to side, he looks balanced. But that "balance" is just a reflection of the structure beneath it. The hours of jump rope, shadowboxing, technique drills, and sparring. His flow didn't come out of nowhere. It came from discipline built in the dark when no one was watching.

When that jab comes (expected or not), he slips it without thinking. Because his foundation is set.

Same thing in life. When you stack your early hours with intention (movement, prayer, training, planning), you armor up for the unknown. Life's punches still land. They just don't knock you out. You recover faster. You recalibrate. You keep going.

Building Your Rhythm

Rhythm starts in the morning. Not because mornings are magical, but because they're yours. Before the world demands

your energy, before phones start buzzing, before everyone else's agenda takes over, you get to choose who you'll be today.

That's why I get up at 3 a.m. Not to be extreme, but to own my hour. In that time, I can train, write, plan, or just sit in silence. By the time the world wakes up, I've already won something. I've already chosen my rhythm for the day.

Your rhythm might look different. Maybe it's 5 a.m. before the kids wake up. Maybe it's your lunch break in your car. Maybe it's after everyone goes to bed. The time doesn't matter. What matters is that it's consistent. That it's yours. That it serves your current season.

The Permission You've Been Waiting For

Here's what I want you to understand: you have permission to stop trying to balance everything. You have permission to go all-in on what matters most right now. You have permission to let some things slide while you build something that actually lasts.

The people around you might not understand. They might think you're not "balanced." But they haven't found their rhythm yet. They're still stuck in the myth that everything has to be equal all the time.

You know better now. You know that sustainable success (whether that's raising strong kids, building a business, or transforming your body) comes from rhythm, not balance. From seasons of intensity followed by seasons of recovery. From choosing what matters most and going all-in, rather than trying to do everything at once.

When Rhythm Gets Tested

Understanding rhythm versus balance is just the beginning. Because once you start building real rhythm in your life, once you start owning your mornings and choosing your seasons, life will test you. Hard.

The resistance will come. From your own mind, from circumstances, from people who don't understand why you're willing to get up at 3 a.m. or say no to their plans. That's when rhythm gets tested. That's when you discover whether you've built something that lasts or just another system that crumbles under pressure.

But if you can build rhythm first, if you can learn to flow with life's seasons instead of fighting them, you'll have what you need to handle whatever comes next.

The world will always try to speed you up. But the strength you're after? The clarity you crave? The legacy you hope to leave?

That only comes when you slow down on purpose. When you choose rhythm over chaos. When you build your life around seasons instead of trying to balance the unbalance-able.

Your rhythm is waiting. The only question is: are you ready to stop chasing balance and start building something that actually works?

Understanding rhythm versus balance is just the beginning. Because once you start building real rhythm in your life, once you start owning your mornings and choosing your seasons,

life will test you. Hard. The resistance will come from places you never expected, in forms you never imagined.

Part 2: The Resistance

Working Through Obstacles, Building Systems, & Helping Others

CHAPTER 6

Discipline is Identity

From Goal to Identity

The kid who walked into my gym at twelve was not an athlete.

Brandon was chubby, non-confident, and didn't play sports. His mom signed him up because she was worried. He spent two summers with me: quiet, uncertain, but showing up. When high school started, I never heard from him again. I figured he was done with training, maybe embarrassed, maybe found something easier.

But talking with his mom months later, I learned the truth: he was now a three-sport athlete. Cross country, basketball, and track. The shy thirteen-year-old who used to avoid eye contact was now competing, contributing, confident enough to try things that once would have terrified him.

Eight years passed before I heard from Brandon again. He called out of the blue, wanting to train again. But this wasn't the same kid. He'd earned his dental degree, was working at a local practice, planning his own someday. And he was

training for both the Boston Marathon and Chicago Marathon.

From a kid who wouldn't even try sports to a man chasing 26.2 miles through the streets of Boston. The weights and sprints didn't just build his body. They built his identity as someone who doesn't quit when things get hard.

That transfers to everything: grinding through dental school when classmates dropped out, starting a practice when it would be easier to stay comfortable as an employee, lacing up for mile twenty when everything in your body screams to stop.

That's the real power of identity-based discipline. It's not just about becoming a better athlete. It's about becoming someone who tackles challenges instead of avoiding them. Someone who shows up when showing up is challenging. Someone who proves to themselves, over and over, that they're reliable, especially when it matters most.

The Shift Most People Miss

Most people chase discipline like it's a skill to develop. Wake up early. Work out consistently. Eat clean. Follow the system.

But that's backwards. Real discipline isn't about what you do. It's about who you are.

I learned this the hard way at fourteen, sneaking back under the covers after my uncle thought I was getting dressed to head out to the farm. I'd justify it: "He won't miss me one morning." "They can start without me."

And they did. He never yelled. Didn't slam doors or call me lazy. But when I walked out later, after the work had started, I saw something in his face. Not anger. Disappointment.

That quiet disappointment hit harder than any lecture because it wasn't about what I'd failed to do. It was about who I'd failed to be. Someone reliable. Someone who keeps their word. Someone the family could count on.

In that moment, I realized I had two choices: I could be the kind of person who shows up, or the kind who finds excuses. Not just for that morning, but for life.

When Identity Gets Tested

Real identity isn't revealed when things are easy. It's forged when everything falls apart.

After my car accident in college, lying in that hospital bed with severed tendons and broken bones, I could have told myself, "I'm not an athlete anymore." The doctors weren't sure I'd regain full use of my left hand. My football career was over.

Instead, I chose a different story.

Two weeks into recovery, I lowered myself to the bedroom floor (left leg in a cast, left hand basically useless). I planted my right hand and my right foot, used what I could of my left hand for balance, and did push-ups.

They weren't pretty. They weren't full range. But they were mine.

In that moment, I wasn't just doing an exercise. I was proving to myself who I still was. Not "I'm trying to get back in shape." But "I'm still the kind of person who doesn't quit."

That's when I learned that identity-based discipline is unbreakable. You can take away the stage, the crowd, the competition. But if discipline lives inside your sense of self, nothing can touch it.

From the Farm to the Family

This principle followed me into fatherhood. When my twins were born, I could have told myself, "I don't have time to train anymore." Sleep deprivation, bottles at 2:45 a.m., three kids under three. Plenty of excuses.

But instead, I asked a different question: "Who do I want to be as a father?"

I wanted to be the dad who models consistency. Who shows his kids that you don't abandon who you are just because life gets difficult. Who proves that taking care of yourself isn't selfish.

So I adapted. Instead of skipping workouts, I trained earlier. Instead of using chaos as an excuse, I used it as motivation. Because I wasn't just "trying to stay in shape." I was being the kind of father who shows up fully for his family.

Every morning I choose discipline over comfort, I'm not just building a habit. I'm reinforcing my identity. I'm proving to myself (and modeling for my kids) that this is who we are. We don't wait for motivation. We don't make excuses. We show up.

The Votes You Cast

Every action you take is a vote for the type of person you are. Miss your alarm? That's a vote for being unreliable. Get up anyway? That's a vote for being disciplined.

The beautiful thing about this system is that you don't need a perfect record to build a strong identity. You just need more votes in the right column.

When I started getting up at 3 a.m. to feed the twins, I wasn't thinking about identity. I was just trying to help my exhausted wife. But every time I chose to get up instead of lying there listening to crying babies, I was casting votes for being the kind of husband and father who leads from the front.

Those votes accumulated. Week by week, month by month, until getting up early wasn't just something I did. It was who I was. The kind of person who owns his morning. Who shows up for his family. Who doesn't need external motivation because internal identity drives everything.

Building Your Identity

Here's how you make the shift from behavior-based discipline to identity-based discipline:

Start with who, not what. Instead of "I want to work out," try "I'm becoming someone who takes care of their body." Instead of "I should read more," try "I'm becoming someone who grows through learning."

Use your morning as proof. Every time you get up early, you're proving you're the kind of person who owns their day. Every time you move your body, you're proving you're

someone who values their health. Stack these small proofs until the identity becomes unshakeable.

Protect the story. When life gets difficult (and it will), you'll be tempted to abandon the discipline. That's when identity matters most. You don't skip the workout because you're tired. You do it because that's who you are.

Let others see it. Your kids, your spouse, your coworkers: they're all watching. When they see you living with consistent discipline, they see what's possible. You become proof that this kind of life can be lived.

The Long Game

This isn't about becoming perfect. It's about becoming consistent with who you choose to be.

Sam Vargas, the kid I trained from baseball player to a record setting sprinter, didn't become an All-American overnight. But every practice, every weight session, every recovery routine stacked up into proof of who he was becoming. Not "a kid chasing a goal." A sprinter.

The same thing happens with discipline. Every early morning, every hard choice, every moment you act from identity instead of impulse, you're building something unbreakable. Not just habits, but character.

Because when life tests you (when the alarm goes off on a hard morning, when you're tired and stressed and looking for an excuse), you won't be asking, "What should I do?"

You'll be saying, “This is who I am!”

And if you've built your identity on discipline, on showing up, on being reliable, the answer will guide you forward. Not because you have to, but because that's who you are.

When Identity Faces Fire

Understanding that discipline is identity changes everything. But it also makes everything more challenging. Because now you're not just trying to build habits. You're trying to become someone new.

The resistance will be fierce. Your old self will fight for survival. Your circumstances will test your resolve. People around you might not understand why you've changed.

But that's exactly why identity-based discipline is so powerful. It's not dependent on feelings, circumstances, or other people's approval. It comes from within. It's unshakeable because it's not about what you do. It's about who you are.

The question isn't whether you can learn to be disciplined. The question is: who are you willing to become?

CHAPTER 7

Burn the Excuses

The First Lie of the Day

Every morning, before you even sit up, there's a voice that whispers the first lie of the day.

"You need more sleep."

"You worked hard yesterday."

"You'll train later."

It's soft. Gentle. Logical. Even comforting. But it's a lie. And every time you listen, you give that voice more power.

I call it **The Negotiator**.

It's not your alarm clock. It's not the dark. It's not the cold floor. It's that voice, disguised as reason, but rooted in avoidance.

When someone counts on you (to go shoulder to shoulder with them, to face the day together) and you're not there, you let them down. Not just them. You.

You realize your word means less. Your bond weakens. Your confidence erodes from the inside.

Can people do it without you? Absolutely. But that's not the point. The point is: they were expecting you. They were hoping you'd show up. That you'd grab a glove or a shovel or a barbell and say, "Let's go."

When you choose sleep over that moment, you don't just miss work. You miss character.

The Daily Negotiation

You know the drill. You had every intention the night before. Clothes laid out. Workout planned. You even told yourself, "Tomorrow, I will get back on track."

Then morning comes.

The edge dulls. The reasons shift. Suddenly, being a little tired feels like a valid excuse. You don't want to push. You want comfort. You want ten more minutes.

But here's the truth: the longer you listen to The Negotiator, the harder it gets to ignore him. And if you cave on the first decision of the day, don't be surprised when the rest of the day follows that same tone.

The Negotiator is smart. He doesn't sound like weakness. He sounds like wisdom:

"You're being too hard on yourself." "Rest is important too." "One day won't matter." "You can start Monday."

Every excuse comes wrapped in logic. Every compromise sounds reasonable. That's what makes him so dangerous.

But here's what The Negotiator doesn't tell you: a missed session isn't just missed sweat. It's momentum lost. Confidence chipped. Character diluted.

Movement Kills Excuses

The moment your feet hit the floor, you take the power back.

The dialogue shifts. It's not about feeling ready. It's about doing it anyway. *"You said you would." "This is who you are." "Get up."*

This isn't about perfection. It's about identity.

That's why I started setting traps for The Negotiator's voice. Clothes set and ready to go. Sit up as soon as I hear the alarm. One deep breath, stand. No thinking. Just moving.

And once I moved, I was free.

Because The Negotiator can't argue with action. He can only argue with hesitation.

The Comfort Trap

Your body can override survival signals if your comfort is strong enough. You can sleep through fire alarms if you want to badly enough. That bed feels like a warm cocoon. You don't want to move. You want five more minutes. You want forever.

In that moment, your comfort is more powerful than your commitment.

But here's what makes waking up on the first alarm different: it's not just a physical act. It's a psychological agreement with yourself.

You made that commitment the night before. You had the talk with yourself, laid out your clothes, prepped the plan, and said, "Tomorrow I start."

So why does it still feel impossible in the moment?

Usually, it's not because you're truly exhausted. It's because you don't feel like it.

And that's what separates wanting from doing.

The War for Your Day

I see it in the clients I train all the time. They come in fired up on day one, ready to overhaul everything. And by week two, that morning fire starts to dim.

That's where the real work begins, not with weights or nutrition, but with discipline.

I tell them the same thing I told myself: don't wait to feel motivated. That moment might not come. Rely on systems, not feelings.

Build friction against the excuses, and make it as easy as possible to move. Because once you move, the battle is already halfway won.

The Negotiator thrives in the gray area between sleep and wakefulness. In that fuzzy moment when your brain is looking for reasons to stay comfortable. But he can't survive movement. He can't survive action.

The Real Enemy

Here's what took me years to understand: The Negotiator isn't trying to protect you from hard work. He's trying to protect you from change.

Because change is uncomfortable. Change requires you to become someone new. Someone who gets up when they don't feel like it. Someone who keeps their word and shows up. Someone who chooses growth over comfort.

The Negotiator wants you to stay exactly who you are. Small. Safe. Unchanged.

That's why he sounds so reasonable. That's why his arguments make so much sense. He's not trying to destroy you. He's trying to preserve you. The old you.

But preservation is just another word for death.

Burning the Voice

Every morning, you have a choice. You can listen to The Negotiator's soft, logical arguments for staying comfortable. Or you can set fire to his voice and stand in the discomfort.

You want change? You want strength? You want clarity? Then burn the excuses.

Call yourself out. Stand in the discomfort. Move before you think.

Because at the end of the day (or the beginning of it), you're either building the person you said you'd be, or you're letting that version slip further away.

The Negotiator will always be there, whispering his reasonable-sounding lies. But you don't have to listen.

You can choose to move instead.

Beyond the Voice

Understanding The Negotiator is just the beginning. Because once you start winning those morning battles, once you start choosing movement over comfort, life will test you in bigger ways.

The resistance will get stronger. More personal. More convincing.

It won't just be about getting out of bed anymore. It'll be about staying committed when your progress stalls. When people around you don't understand. When your own past tries to drag you backward.

That's when you'll discover whether you've truly burned the excuses or just quieted them temporarily.

The Negotiator never really dies. He just gets quieter when you stop listening. But he's always waiting for a moment of weakness, a crack in your resolve, a reason to whisper those comfortable lies again.

The question isn't whether you can silence him forever. The question is: will you choose to move anyway?

Because in the end, discipline isn't about eliminating The Negotiator. It's about refusing to negotiate.

CHAPTER 8

When Life Derails You

The Carpet Decision

Two weeks into recovery, I rolled off that hospital bed onto the old shag carpet in our living room. My left leg stayed on the bed, immobilized in its brace. My left hand was useless except for the thumb and index finger.

The carpet smelled like childhood: motor oil, cheap plastic, summer afternoons. I planted my right hand flat against those fibers. Dug my fingernails into the tight weave for traction. Used what I could of my left hand for balance.

Then I pushed.

My right arm shook. My core twisted. My broken left side screamed. I got maybe four inches off the ground before collapsing back down.

I lay there for a minute, face pressed into musty carpet, and started laughing. Not happy laughing. The kind that's real close to crying.

This was my rep. After two weeks of lying around feeling sorry for myself, this was my comeback: four inches off the carpet with one arm.

But you know what? It was four more inches than yesterday.

Invincible

That push-up existed because of a choice I'd made three weeks earlier...

Thirteen hours of sleep in five days.

I wore it like a badge of honor, bragging to anyone who'd listen. My girlfriend thought I was insane. My uncle just shook his head. But I was twenty years old and bulletproof, convinced that discipline meant never stopping, never slowing down, never admitting you had limits.

Summer of 1998. Up at 4 a.m. to milk cows with Uncle John. Shower, gym, then afternoons baling hay under a sun that turned the tractor cab into an oven. Evenings at the go-kart track in the Dells until midnight. My girlfriend worked there too, so after closing we'd hang out and talk until 2 or 3 a.m. Then home by 3 a.m. to do it all again.

Most nights I didn't even change out of my work clothes. Coffee and caffeine pills kept me wired. Youth and arrogance kept me stupid.

I was getting stronger. Put on twenty pounds of muscle that summer. My bench press jumped forty pounds. I thought I'd figured out the formula: more work equals more results. Sleep is for the weak. Rest is for quitters.

One morning after I nearly fell asleep standing up while milking, Uncle John finally spoke.

"You trying to prove something, or you trying to kill yourself?"

"I'm fine," I said. "This is what it takes."

He just nodded, went back to work. But I saw it in his eyes. That concerned and wise look that said: this won't end well.

The Last Drive

August 8th, 1998. Saturday night. Two weeks before our season started.

I finished up at the go-kart track around midnight and had a night cap with my girlfriend until 2:30am. I could have gone straight home, grabbed four hours of sleep. Instead, I grabbed a Mountain Dew from the vending machine, cranked the radio, and pointed my car toward home.

Highway Z is a narrow two-lane road that cuts through farm country. No streetlights. Just darkness and cornfields and the occasional deer. I knew every curve, every dip, every bad patch of pavement. I'd driven it a thousand times.

I remember setting the aluminum can in the cup holder. I remember blaring *White Zombie* on my CD player. I remember thinking about just getting home.

Then my eyelids got heavy.

I blinked hard, shook my head, rolled down the window. The August air was thick and warm, no help. My body was screaming at me, every cell begging for sleep. Just pull over, it said. Just stop.

But I was less than a mile from home. One more mile. I could make it.

I blinked again.

The steering wheel jerked in my hands. A tree filled my windshield. The metal scream of impact. Glass exploding. My body folding in ways bodies shouldn't fold.

Then just pain. Pure, white-hot, all-consuming pain.

The Inventory

My left knee had split open on impact, crushed and twisted up toward my ear. My ankle was broken underneath me, twisted beneath the seat. My left hand hung forward, sliced open where the windshield had come through. Two tendons severed clean. Blood poured down my wrist.

The screams tore out of my throat. Later they'd tell me people heard them over a mile away.

Someone appeared at the passenger window. Wanda, from the house nearby. My headlight had torn off on impact and hit the siding of her house, waking her up.

"I just want to go to sleep," I kept saying through the screams. "Please just let me sleep."

"Stay awake, honey," she said, pushing a blanket through the broken window. "Help is coming."

The hydraulic sound of the Jaws of Life reminded me of farm equipment. That same industrial hiss and groan. They cut the seats out from behind me. Removed me through the roof like cargo.

The helicopter ride is blank. Just darkness and the constant noise of rotor blades.

I woke up in a hallway under fluorescent lights, being wheeled somewhere. My parents and oldest sister standing over me, faces of shock with something I'd never seen before. Not anger. Utter fear.

"What are you guys doing here?" I asked.

My mom started crying.

"It's time to get up and milk cows," I said, confused why everyone looked so serious.

The Breaking

The surgeon came in around 6 a.m. He had that practiced calm that doctors use when delivering bad news.

Left knee: patellar fracture with severe crushing. Ligament damage. Bone fragments. A reconstruction job that would take months to heal.

Left hand: two tendons severed. Clean through. They'd try to reattach them, try to restore function. Might not work. Might never fully close my hand again.

Left ankle: broken, dislocated. Torn ligaments. Bone chips floating around in there like gravel.

Chest: massive hematoma from the seatbelt. Every breath felt like getting kicked by a horse. But that seatbelt had saved my life by inches.

"You're lucky to be alive," he said.

Lucky. That word landed wrong. Lucky would have been staying home. Lucky would have been pulling over. Lucky would have been listening to Uncle John.

This wasn't luck. This was consequence.

The Call

Coach Nielson called on the third day. His voice came through the phone with that careful tone people use when they're not sure how bad things really are.

"How you feeling, Buck?"

"Like shit, coach."

Silence. I could hear the TV in the background on his side, sports highlights probably. On mine, a soap opera was playing. *The Young and the Restless*. I stared at the ceiling tiles while we both searched for words.

"Team's looking good," he finally said. "Gonna be a strong year."

I knew what he wasn't saying. They were going to be good without me. The season I'd trained for, the one I'd nearly killed myself preparing for, was going to happen whether I was there or not.

My roommate from school called. "Dude, we heard. That sucks. You gonna be okay?"

"Yeah," I said. "I'll be fine."

But I wasn't fine. My football career was over. The body I'd built over four years was already starting to atrophy. Everything I'd worked for was melting away while I lay in bed

watching soap operas. *Why do we only get three channels*, I grumbled.

The girlfriend called every day for the first week. By the second week, the calls came every other day. She had college starting, a new life waiting. I could hear it in her voice: sympathy turning to distance. I was becoming a summer memory.

Nobody said it out loud, but I felt it: life was moving on without me.

The Conversation with Myself

Two weeks in, I'd had enough.

Not just of the bed, the TV, the helplessness. I'd had enough of the conversation in my head. The one that kept playing on repeat:

This is what you get for being stupid.

You did this to yourself.

You thought you were invincible.

I knew that voice. It was the same one that told me sleep was for the weak. Rest was for quitters. More work always equals more results.

That voice had driven me all summer. And that voice had nearly killed me.

Sitting in that bed, I realized something that would change everything: I'd confused discipline with invincibility. I thought pushing past limits meant ignoring them completely. I thought being tough meant never admitting weakness.

But Uncle John was the toughest man I knew, and he took naps after breakfast. He worked hard, then he rested hard. He knew rhythm wasn't about going 100% all the time. It was about going 100% at the right times, then recovering so you could do it again.

Real discipline includes wisdom. It knows when to push and when to back off. It listens to the body's warnings instead of treating them like challenges to overcome.

I'd been treating my body like an enemy to conquer instead of a partner to respect.

The First Rep

Which brings me back to that carpet. That pathetic, beautiful, one-armed pushup...

I pushed again. Got to six inches this time. Five more reps. Each one a little higher. By the tenth rep, I was getting my chest fully off the ground.

My mom walked in from the kitchen.

"Glen, what are you doing? You're supposed to be resting."

"I'm done resting," I said.

The push-up wasn't about strength. I'd lost strength and would lose more before this was over. It wasn't about proving I could still train.

It was about proving I could still choose. That being broken didn't mean being powerless. That I still had agency over my own recovery, my own future, my own identity.

The car accident had taken away my football season. But it didn't have to take away who I was underneath that. I was still the kid who got up at 4 a.m. to work the farm. Still the guy who chose discipline over comfort. Still someone who didn't quit when things got hard.

But now I knew something I didn't know before: discipline without wisdom is just slow-motion destruction. Real strength isn't about ignoring your body's limits. It's about respecting them while pushing just past the edge of comfortable.

That summer, I'd been grinding myself into the ground, confusing exhaustion with excellence. And it had nearly killed me.

This push-up was different. It was earned. It was honest. It was the start of learning how to build strength that could last.

The Long Road Back

The rebuild took months. Physical therapy three times a week. Learning to close my hand again, one millimeter at a time. I taught myself tissue work, experimented with recovery methods nobody was talking about yet. Figured out solutions because waiting for permission to heal wasn't in my nature.

I missed the entire 1998 football season. Watched from the sidelines as my team had one of their best years in program history. Every game was a reminder of what I'd lost to one stupid decision on a dark road.

But slowly, steadily, I came back. Not to who I was before, but to something better. Someone who understood that the strongest foundation isn't built on pushing through

everything. It's built on the wisdom to know when to push and when to adapt.

The Lesson

Here's what the car accident taught me that no workout ever could: Your body will tell you the truth if you listen. The fatigue I'd been ignoring all summer wasn't weakness. It was data. My body was saying: this is unsustainable. This is dangerous. This is going to break.

I just didn't want to hear it or accept it.

I'd been taught that discipline meant pushing through. That real men don't complain about being tired. That limits are just challenges to overcome.

But limits exist for a reason. They're not your enemy. They're your protection. And when you consistently ignore them, they find a way to make you listen.

Mine made me listen through a tree on Highway Z.

Twenty-five years later, I can close my left hand completely. Something the doctors said might never happen. The scars are still visible. My knee clicks when I squat heavy.

But I'm still training. Still moving. Still showing up at 3 a.m.

Not because I'm trying to prove something. Not because I'm grinding myself into dust. But because I learned the difference between discipline and destruction. Between working hard and working smart. Between pushing through and adapting around.

The greatest gift that accident gave me wasn't sympathy or a dramatic story. It was the understanding that when something

doesn't work, you don't give up. You figure out a different way. You work at it until the impossible becomes possible.

Real discipline respects the vessel it's building. And when you respect it, work at it, refuse to accept limitations, the results can be amazing.

Sometimes, it takes getting broken to learn how to build something that lasts.

CHAPTER 9

When People Don’t Understand

The Price of Growth

You can rebuild from physical setbacks. You can recover from circumstances beyond your control. But what happens when the people closest to you think your new discipline makes you extreme, obsessed, or just plain crazy?

That's when you discover that sometimes the biggest resistance to your growth doesn't come from life's circumstances. It comes from people who love you.

The 3 a.m. Question

"You're not right."

That's what friends and family say when they hear about my 3 a.m. routine. The same people who ask, "How do you find time to write a book?" or "When do you work out?" They want the results but think the method is insane.

I watch these conversations happen at my gym every day. Parents drop their kids off for training, then sit in their cars

scrolling their phones or catching up on work. They see me moving with energy late in the day after a full schedule, and they ask, "How do you have time to train? When do you do bodybuilding shows?"

The answer is simple: I don't *have* time. I *create* time by doing it earlier.

But they don't want to hear that. They want a secret that doesn't require sacrifice. They want discipline without the accountability part.

When Friendship Tests Boundaries

The hardest lesson about boundaries came from a long-time client I'll call Jason.

For years, Jason had been part of my core group, one of the originals who'd been with me since Wisconsin Barbell started. He'd show up consistently, help with small things around the gym, even take care of my dog when I needed it. Our relationship ran deeper than trainer and client. He was family.

That's exactly why what happened hit so hard.

Over time, the group dynamics shifted. Life happened: retirements, job changes, families growing. People's availability changed, and I was trying to accommodate everyone while also pursuing new projects I'd put on hold for years. Coding, app development, the technology work I'd always dreamed about, doing more than just training.

I was starting to resent my schedule. More importantly, I was starting to resent myself. I'd become so close to my clients that I was afraid to have the conversations that would benefit

everyone. Mention boundaries? I'd feel guilty. Talk about protecting my time? I'd worry they'd think I didn't care.

The tension had been building for months. After a recent event where I'd finally gotten to use my programming skills again, I was determined to carve out more time for this work. I needed space to grow, not just as a trainer, but as a person.

Then came the moment that changed everything.

Jason arrived earlier than his scheduled training time one day, right in the middle of my development time. When I asked about the timing, his response cut deep: "You don't really train me anyway. You don't have to watch me."

Everything I thought I knew about our relationship (the encouragement I gave, the energy I brought, the way I checked in with everyone) all of it felt negated in that moment.

My frustration finally boiled over. "When do I have time to do what I need to do?"

He grabbed his things. "That's fine. I understand."

And he left. Never came back.

I reached out later, trying to explain how burnt out I was getting from not honoring my own boundaries. But the damage was done.

The Guilt Machine

A week later, Jason sent me a message: "Remember when we were still friends?"

The ultimate guilt factor. The suggestion that setting boundaries meant ending friendship. That choosing to protect my time and energy was somehow a betrayal.

"We're still friends," I replied. "I just need my time to actually get work done."

But the relationship had changed. The friendship survived, but it transformed into something different. Maybe that's what had to happen. Maybe some relationships can only exist when boundaries are blurry, and they can't survive when you start honoring your own needs.

The Pattern Reveals Itself

This wasn't an isolated incident. I saw it with other clients too.

There was the guy who started showing up earlier and earlier because "I couldn't sleep anyway," as if his insomnia was my issue to alleviate. The woman who wanted to chat between sets when I was trying to prep for my next session. The athlete whose parents expected special treatment because they'd been with me "for years."

Each time, the same lesson: people will push against your boundaries until you either hold them or abandon them entirely.

They were trying to be friendly. But they didn't understand that my early morning time wasn't social hour. This was my foundation. My meditation. My reset button for everything that would follow.

Losing Your Support System

The resistance isn't always direct. Sometimes it's just life moving people in different directions.

After my first year of college, I lost my training partner Rudy to a mission trip and his relocation to Utah. That's another reason I eventually started training alone in the early mornings. I needed solitude. I needed space where my discipline belonged to *me*, not to anyone else's schedule or expectations. Other people noticed and new friendships and training partners emerged.

I was almost failing out of school and didn't have direction. A good friend of mine, Erik, stepped in and said something that changed my life: "Dude, you live in the gym. You should just do something with that." He saw my desire to train. My purpose.

Just like that, I course-corrected from criminal justice to kinesiology. Found my passion. Found my path. But I also learned that support systems are fragile. People move on. Partners change directions. Discipline that depends on others is discipline that can be taken away. But with every closed door another one will open.

The Loneliness of Standards

Here's what I've learned about discipline and relationships: the more committed you become to your standards, the more you'll stand out. And standing out makes some people uncomfortable.

They'll call you obsessive. Unbalanced. Extreme. They'll suggest you need more "balance" in your life, usually meaning you should lower your standards to match theirs.

This isn't malicious. Most people genuinely believe they're helping. They see the effort you're putting in and worry you're pushing too hard. They see the sacrifices you're making and think you're missing out on life.

What they don't see is that discipline doesn't make life smaller. It makes it bigger. Getting up early doesn't steal time from my family. It gives me more energy and presence when I'm with them. Going to bed early doesn't mean I'm antisocial. It means I'm preparing to show up fully the next day.

But explaining this gets old. Eventually, you realize you're not trying to convince others anymore. You're trying to stay true to what you know works, even when you're the only one who understands why.

The Support You Actually Need

Not everyone will get it. Your spouse might need more reassurance than you think is necessary. Your friends might think your routine is extreme. Your family might worry you're becoming someone they don't recognize.

That's okay. You don't need everyone to understand. You just need a few people who do.

For me, that's been training partners who show up consistently. Clients who respect boundaries. A men's group that meets occasionally but calls each other out when needed.

These aren't people who enable my excuses. They're people who understand my standards.

The Real Test

The real test of your discipline isn't whether people understand it. It's whether you can maintain it even when they don't.

When your wife thinks you're being antisocial. When your friends think you're being extreme. When clients push against your boundaries. When family members suggest you need more "balance."

This is where most people cave. They lower their standards to avoid conflict. They sacrifice their discipline to keep the peace. They choose comfort over growth because growth is lonely.

But here's what I've discovered: the people who truly matter will eventually see the results and understand. Maybe not the method, but the outcome. They'll see that you're more present because you've taken care of yourself first. They'll see that you're more reliable because your discipline is unshakeable. They'll see that your "obsession" with routine has made you a better partner, parent, and friend.

And the people who can't see that? They probably weren't going to support your growth anyway.

CHAPTER 10

When Progress Stalls

The Halfway Point

Week six of bodybuilding prep. Halfway to the stage, halfway to the goal, and completely lost in no-man's land.

I'm standing in front of my bathroom mirror at 5 a.m., shirt off, examining what twelve weeks of discipline is supposed to create. The lighting is harsh, unforgiving. My belly still folds over my underwear when I bend to put on socks. The scale hasn't budged in five days. Worse, it went up yesterday.

This is the danger zone. Not the beginning, when motivation runs high and progress comes fast. Not the end, when the finish line pulls you forward. This is the boring middle, where doubt lives and dreams go to die.

Most people quit here. Right here, at the halfway point, when the initial excitement has worn off but the payoff still feels impossibly far away.

Doubt Riding Shotgun

Doubt doesn't whisper. It speaks with the confidence of a GPS that knows exactly where you're going wrong.

During my drive to the gym each morning, doubt rides shotgun, tapping its fingers on the dashboard like my wife does when I miss an exit. "Are you sure this is working?" it asks. "Why didn't you cheat yesterday when everyone else was having fun?" "Look at how far you still have to go."

The rearview mirror becomes my enemy. It shows me all the missteps, all the meals that could have been cleaner, all the cardio sessions that could have been longer. Rarely do I look back and think, "Yeah, I'm definitely going the right way."

The road ahead stretches endlessly. Each mile marker (each day, each meal, each workout) feels longer than the last. What seemed manageable at the start now feels like crossing a desert with a teaspoon of water.

But I keep driving. Because stopping here means starting over.

When Business Feels Pointless

The gym tells the same story every fall.

Summer was incredible. Groups of twelve to fifteen kids, each paying fifteen dollars an hour. Doctor and lawyer money, my wife called it, watching the cash flow from young athletes preparing for fall sports.

Now it's September. After-school hours that were once packed are ghost towns. One kid shows up. Sometimes zero.

I sit in my empty gym, calculating overhead and wondering if I should get a second job.

This happened every year for the first five years. Every September, I questioned everything. Maybe I should have stayed in law enforcement. Maybe I should have taken that corporate job my client offered. Maybe the grass really is greener somewhere else.

But here's what I learned about plateaus: they're not failure signs. They're tests.

The parents who pulled their kids from summer training? They're calling in November, panicking because their athlete is getting beat by kids who never stopped training. The clients who disappeared when motivation wore off? They're back in January, heavier and weaker than when they left.

Consistency during the plateau is what separates those who succeed from those who quit and restart every few months.

I kept showing up. Empty gym or full gym, I was there. And slowly, steadily, the athletes returned. Not because I was perfect, but because I was reliable.

The Relationship Toll

"You're no fun anymore," my wife says. "Other couples go out on Friday nights. You're asleep by nine."

These words cut deeper than she knows. Not because they're cruel, but because they reveal how discipline looks from the outside: rigid, joyless, extreme.

I try explaining: "I do this for our family. When I take care of myself first, I show up better for everyone else."

But explanations sound hollow when you're missing social events, turning down dinner invitations, going to bed when others are just getting started.

Here's the truth about discipline plateaus in relationships: the results take time to show, but the sacrifices are immediate. People see what you're giving up before they see what you're gaining.

My wife sees me going to bed early. She doesn't see me waking up energized and present for our kids. She sees me meal-prepping on Sundays. She doesn't see me staying calm under pressure because my blood sugar is stable.

This is where most people cave. They choose social comfort over personal growth. They sacrifice their discipline to keep the peace.

But I've learned something: people who truly love you will eventually see the results, even if they don't understand the method.

When Strength Stops Growing

Physical plateaus are the cruelest teachers.

For months, maybe years, you add weight to the bar every week. Progress feels automatic, inevitable. Then suddenly, it stops. The 315-pound bench press you've been chasing for months stays just out of reach. Your squat refuses to budge. Your body weight hovers in the same five-pound range no matter what you do.

This is where most gym memberships go to die. When the motivation wears off and the linear progress ends. When

showing up stops feeling rewarding and starts feeling pointless.

But here's what plateaus actually mean: you're strong enough now that your body demands precision. It's no longer enough to just show up and go through the motions. Every rep has to count. Every meal has to serve a purpose. Every hour of sleep becomes important.

Plateaus aren't your body giving up. They're your body demanding that you level up.

The difference between someone who breaks through and someone who quits is simple: patience. The willingness to keep showing up when progress is invisible. To trust the process when the process feels broken.

The Test

Ben Askren teaches this better than anyone. Olympic wrestler, UFC fighter, social media personality with a million followers.

At forty-two, he was living the life most athletes dream of. Then, in 2025, a staph infection nearly killed him. Forty-five days in a coma. Complete lung transplant. When he woke up, he literally got to see his own obituary: got to read what people would have said about him if he hadn't made it.

His first message back to the world was simple: "I had self-doubt, but only for a minute."

That's the difference between champions and everyone else. Not the absence of doubt (everyone has doubt). It's how long you let doubt drive the car.

Plateaus aren't punishment for doing something wrong. They're preparation for doing something bigger. They're where you prove whether your discipline is real or just a hobby.

The weight that won't budge is teaching you patience. The business that won't grow is teaching you persistence. The relationship tension is teaching you communication. The body that won't change is teaching you to trust the process over the mirror.

Most people quit here because this is where discipline stops being fun and starts being character.

The Choice

Every plateau asks the same question: How badly do you want this?

Not when it's easy. Not when progress is obvious. Not when people are cheering. But right here, in the boring middle, when doubt is loud and results are quiet.

You can quit. Nobody would blame you. You can blame genetics, circumstances, bad luck. You can tell yourself you gave it a shot and it just wasn't meant to be.

Or you can understand that this is exactly where champions are made. In the space between giving up and breaking through. In the daily choice to show up when showing up feels pointless.

Because here's what I've learned from every plateau I've survived: the breakthrough isn't usually dramatic. It's not a sudden explosion of progress that makes everything worth it.

The breakthrough is the realization that you're no longer the kind of person who quits when things get hard. That somewhere in the boring middle, you became someone who sees things through.

And that person (the one who doesn't quit at the halfway point) can accomplish anything.

The Enemy Within

You can survive plateaus. You can push through doubt, business slowdowns, relationship tension, and physical stagnation. You can become the kind of person who doesn't quit when progress stalls.

But what happens when the problem isn't external circumstances or temporary plateaus? What happens when the battle is internal, when your old identity fights back against the new person you're becoming?

That's when you discover that the hardest person to defeat isn't doubt. It's who you used to be.

CHAPTER 11

When Your Past Fights Back

The Drunk Uncle

I was spinning in circles at my cousin's backyard party, laughing like an idiot, when my feet tangled and I hit the ground hard.

From the grass, still giggling like a fool, I looked up to see five-year-old Addelyn staring down at me. Those big blue eyes weren't laughing. They were concerned, confused, maybe a little scared. Her mouth slightly open as if in disbelief and worry. Like something was wrong with Uncle Glen.

That's when it hit me: I was becoming *that* uncle.

We always made fun of our drunk uncles growing up. As one of 20+ cousins at weddings and Christmas parties, we always had that one guy who brought his own beer, came with all smiles and dance moves, then became the staggering blubbery mess by night's end. It reminded me of college: the guy I didn't want to go back to because I had no control over him.

Watching those *Incredible Hulk* TV shows with my lifting partner Rudy, I realized I was like the Hulk: uncontrollable,

too strong for most people, and all in all a lumbering idiot. The point where I could go from one to two beers and feel good didn't work anymore. It was one to ten, then hitting that wall where my legs were on rubber street. It was like being knocked down in the boxing ring with a stiff right cross to my temple, I was like a baby giraffe trying to get up.

When I drank, I would go to extremes for what felt like a good time to me but was horrible for everyone else. Instead of partying with a buddy and friend, it became babysitting an overgrown man-child.

I saw the shame in her eyes. My cousin laughed and said, "Oh, there's Glen stumbling drunk," but it wasn't her and I as young kids laughing at our uncle. It was her laughing at me.

I thought to myself, *What the f--- am I doing?*

I slowly got up, brushed the grass off my knees, and watched my little cousin run away to play. As if I saw her run off into the sunset, never to let her know how deeply sorry I was. But she was too young to understand. I was an idiot. I was foolish.

In that moment, lying on the ground with my cousin's daughter looking at me like I was broken, I saw myself clearly for the first time in years. This wasn't "fun Glen" having a good time. This was a grown man making a fool of himself in front of a child who looked up to him.

The party continued around me, but something fundamental had shifted. The old Glen (the one who got to parties early to man the keg, who thought being drunk by 9 p.m. was hilarious) was fighting for his life. But he was losing.

The War Inside

Your old identity doesn't go quietly. It fights back with everything it has, because it knows what you know: one of you has to die for the other to live.

For years, I'd been living a split existence. Monday through Friday, I was disciplined Glen: up early, training hard, eating clean, building a business. But weekends? Weekends belonged to college Glen, the guy who thought fun meant getting wasted and acting stupid.

I told myself I had balance. That I could be both people. That discipline during the week earned me the right to be reckless on weekends.

But you can't serve two masters. You can't build character five days a week and tear it down for two. Eventually, one identity wins, and the other dies.

That night, watching Addelyn's face, I chose which one would survive.

The People-Pleaser Dies Hard

The old Glen didn't just like to party. He was also the guy who said yes to everything. Who never raised his prices in eighteen years of business because he "didn't want to turn anyone away." Who let clients show up whenever they wanted because he was afraid of conflict.

By 2025, that nice-guy approach was killing me. Inflation had hammered my costs, but I was still charging what I charged in 2007. My gym had become chaos: adults mixing with kids, people showing up at random times, no structure, no boundaries.

I was resentful, exhausted, and angry. But still too afraid to change anything.

The old Glen whispered his familiar lies: "They'll leave if you raise prices. They won't like the new rules. You'll lose clients. Just keep being nice."

But nice wasn't working anymore. Nice was making me bitter. Nice was turning my sacred space into a free-for-all that served nobody well.

I did something the old Glen never would have done: I set boundaries.

I raised my prices. I implemented scheduled training times. I told clients they needed to show up when they said they would or find somewhere else to train.

The old Glen was terrified. But the new Glen (the father, the business owner, the man with responsibilities) knew it was time to stop apologizing for having standards.

When Marriage Changes Everything

Being single and disciplined is easy. You're disciplined for yourself, your goals, your dating prospects. But marriage changes the game completely.

Suddenly, discipline isn't just about you anymore. It's about "us." And if your spouse doesn't share your level of commitment to early mornings and meal prep, you're in for a fight.

After my shoulder injury derailed my powerlifting training, I threw myself into flying lessons. I received my pilot's license within a year. But when it came time to start a family, I had to

make another identity shift: from pilot, back to trainer, from adventure-seeker, to provider.

That meant selling the dream of weekend flights for the reality of weekend family time. It meant saving money instead of spending it on aviation fuel. It meant accepting that the single guy who could chase any passion was dead.

For a while, I lost myself in that transition. I gained thirty pounds because I stopped caring about my diet. I stopped looking like someone who owned a gym and looked like I should be at the gym.

My wife noticed, of course. "Looks like you put on a few pounds," she said one day, and even though she was joking, the words stung because they were true.

I was angry: at her for saying it, at myself for letting it happen, at the situation for forcing me to choose between old dreams and new responsibilities.

But anger is just grief in disguise. I wasn't angry about the weight. I was grieving the death of single Glen, pilot Glen, guy-with-no-responsibilities Glen.

The Identity Graveyard

Here's what nobody tells you about growth: it requires murder.

Not literal murder, but the systematic killing of old versions of yourself that no longer serve who you're becoming. And those old selves don't go quietly. They fight back with nostalgia, fear, and the seductive whisper that change isn't worth the pain.

College Glen fought by telling me I was becoming boring, that discipline was just another word for joyless. People-pleaser Glen fought by convincing me that boundaries would drive everyone away. Single Glen fought by making marriage feel like a prison instead of a partnership.

But here's the truth: those old identities weren't serving me anymore. They were holding me back.

College Glen got me lying on the ground at family parties, embarrassing myself in front of children. People-pleaser Glen had me working for 2007 wages in 2025, resenting every client who took advantage of my inability to say no. Single Glen was keeping me from fully investing in my marriage and family.

They had to die. Not because they were evil, but because they were outdated software running on new hardware.

The Execution

Killing old identities isn't dramatic. It's a series of small deaths, quiet choices that accumulate over time.

I stopped going to parties where the main activity was getting drunk. That was the death of party Glen.

I raised my prices and enforced boundaries with clients. That was the death of people-pleaser Glen.

I chose family time over adventure time, saving money over spending it on hobbies. That was the death of single Glen.

Each death felt like loss at first. I mourned the fun I thought I was giving up, the adventures I wouldn't have, the easy relationships I was complicating with boundaries.

But something beautiful happened: as the old identities died, space opened up for new ones to be born.

Father Glen emerged: present, responsible, someone his kids could look up to without concern or confusion.

Business owner Glen appeared: confident in his value, clear about his standards, respectful of his own time and energy.

Husband Glen developed: committed not just to being married, but to being worth being married to.

The Resurrection

This isn't a story about loss. It's a story about evolution.

The discipline that felt like restriction became freedom. The boundaries that felt harsh became protective. The standards that felt demanding became magnetic.

When I stopped being available to everyone, I became more valuable to the people who mattered. When I stopped saying yes to everything, my yes began to mean something. When I stopped trying to be all things to all people, I became exactly who my family needed me to be.

The old Glen who needed external validation was replaced by a man who validates himself through consistent action. The old Glen who measured success by how much people liked him was replaced by a man who measures success by how well he serves his values.

That's what growth actually looks like: not addition, but transformation. Not becoming more of who you were, but becoming who you were meant to be.

The Ultimate Test

You can survive the death of old identities. You can choose growth over comfort, boundaries over people-pleasing, responsibility over freedom. You can become someone new.

But what happens when that growth is tested to its absolute limit? When everything you've built (your discipline, your identity, your sense of control) gets stripped away in a single moment?

That's when you discover whether you've truly changed or just been playing dress-up. That's when you find out if your new identity can survive complete devastation.

Because sometimes, before you can fully become who you're meant to be, everything has to break first.

CHAPTER 12

The Breaking Point

When Everything Stops

The hospital ceiling had exactly 247 tiles. I counted them seventeen times while lying there with my left leg folded like a pretzel, my hand barely functional, and my football career bleeding out somewhere on Highway Z.

This wasn't supposed to happen. Not to me. Not when I was finally getting somewhere. Not when I had plans, goals, a future I could see clearly for the first time in my life.

But life doesn't care about your plans.

Lying in that bed, drifting in and out of consciousness from pain medication, I had a choice to make. The same choice everyone faces when everything they've built gets stripped away in a single moment:

Break down, or break through.

The Moment of Truth

Two weeks into recovery, I'd had enough of staring at soap operas on three fuzzy TV channels. Enough of being helpless. Enough of lying there like a victim while my body turned to mush and my mind spiraled into self-pity.

I rolled off that bed onto the old shag carpet, my left side screaming in protest. Everything hurt. My knee was immobilized. My hand barely worked, just the thumb and index finger responding to commands from my brain. The smart thing would have been to stay in bed, to rest, to let my body heal the way the doctors ordered.

Instead, I planted my right hand flat on the carpet and pushed.

That push-up changed everything. Not because it was impressive (it wasn't). I looked like a broken toy trying to function with half its parts missing. But because it was a choice. A declaration that I wasn't done. That being broken didn't mean being defeated.

Every rep hurt. Every rep was crooked, unbalanced, pathetic by any normal standard. But every rep was also proof: I was still here. I could still fight. I could still build something, even if I had to rebuild it differently than before.

I know I shared this experience, but it was the breaking point. The moment I learned that rock bottom isn't where you stop. It's where you decide who you're going to become.

The Pattern Reveals Itself

Breaking points don't announce themselves. They accumulate like hairline cracks in a windshield until one day, something hits just right and everything shatters.

The gym taught me this lesson over and over. Year five of Wisconsin Barbell, sitting in an empty facility at 3 p.m., wondering if I should get a second job. The overhead was eating me alive, clients were sparse, and every business guru said I was charging too little to survive.

But I'd learned something from that hospital bed: breaking points are choice points.

I could close the gym and find "real work" (what everyone expected, what would have been easier, what my practical side whispered I should do). Or I could show up tomorrow, and the day after, and keep showing up until the tide turned.

I chose to show up. Not because I felt confident, but because I'd proven to myself that I was the kind of person who doesn't quit when things get hard.

Same pattern, different crisis. The powerlifting injury that stripped away 300 pounds from my bench press. The moments at 2:45 a.m. with crying twins when every cell in my body screamed for sleep. The business decisions that required me to finally raise prices after eighteen years, knowing I might lose clients I'd trained for decades.

Each time, the same choice: break down or break through.

The 2:45 a.m. Test

Nothing prepares you for the relentless exhaustion of twins. Brooklyn had been manageable: challenging but doable. Two babies needing bottles, diapers, attention at all hours? That's a different level of warfare.

2:45 a.m. became my breaking point every single night for months.

The alarm would sound, and everything in my body would beg me to roll over, to let my wife handle it just this once, to steal another hour of sleep. The Negotiator would whisper his familiar lies: "You need rest. You've got a full day ahead. She can manage."

But I learned something fundamental from that hospital carpet: the person you become in your breaking moments is the person you become everywhere else.

So I got up. Not because I felt like it, but because this was who I was now. The kind of father who leads from the front. The kind of husband who doesn't wait for someone else to handle the hard stuff.

Those 2:45 a.m. moments taught me that discipline isn't about big heroic acts. It's about small choices made in the dark when no one's watching and everyone would understand if you took the easy way out.

When Your Body Breaks

The nerve injury that ended my powerlifting training was perhaps the worst breaking point of all. At least the car accident was sudden: no time to see it coming, no choice in the matter. But the injury happened slowly, progressively,

giving me plenty of time to watch my strength disappear day by day.

135 pounds felt like 405. My left side atrophied visibly. Everything I'd built over years of disciplined training evaporated like morning mist.

I could have done what most people do: make peace with decline, accept that my best days were behind me, transition gracefully into being a "former" athlete.

Instead, I became a rehabilitation machine.

If mainstream medicine said rest was best, I found movement-based therapies. If conventional wisdom said to avoid the injured area, I worked on blood flow and gentle activation. If everyone else was waiting for permission to heal, I was experimenting on myself with techniques that wouldn't become popular for another decade.

Not because I was smarter than the doctors, but because I'd learned that breaking points reveal who you really are. And I wasn't someone who accepted defeat gracefully. I was someone who found another way.

The Business Breaking Point

Eighteen years without raising prices. Eighteen years of inflation eating my margins while I charged what I charged in 2007. By 2025, I was drowning financially but terrified to change anything.

The old Glen whispered his people-pleasing lies: "They'll leave. They'll think you're greedy. You'll lose everyone you've built relationships with."

But I was dying slowly, resentment building like pressure in a boiler. The very kindness I thought I was showing was turning me bitter, angry, exhausted.

That was the breaking point: realizing that my unwillingness to set boundaries wasn't serving anyone. Not me, not my family, not even my clients who were getting a trainer who was stressed and overwhelmed instead of focused and present.

I raised prices. Implemented scheduled training times. Told clients they needed to show up when they said they would or find somewhere else to train.

Some left. Most stayed. And something beautiful happened: the clients who remained were the ones who valued what I offered, who respected boundaries, who wanted to be part of something intentional rather than chaotic.

The breaking point taught me that boundaries aren't walls that keep people out. They're foundations that keep the right people in.

The Choice That Defines You

Here's what every breaking point has taught me: you don't get to choose when they come, but you always get to choose what they mean.

The hospital bed could have been the end of my athletic story. Instead, it became the beginning of my comeback story.

The business struggles could have been proof I wasn't cut out for entrepreneurship. Instead, they became lessons in persistence and the power of showing up consistently.

The nerve injury could have been my excuse to become a "former" athlete. Instead, it became my invitation to become something bigger: a coach who understands both strength and vulnerability.

The 2:45 a.m. moments could have been evidence that I was overwhelmed and failing as a father. Instead, they became proof that I was the kind of dad who does whatever it takes to serve his family.

What Breaking Points Actually Are

Breaking points aren't punishments. They're not evidence that you're weak or unlucky or destined to fail. They're tests, but not the kind that judge whether you're good enough.

They're the kind that reveal who you already are underneath the surface. They strip away the excuses, the comfortable stories, the elaborate plans you've made for how your life should unfold.

And in that stripped-down moment, when everything you thought you could count on is gone, you discover what you're actually made of.

The discipline you've built in the easy times (getting up early when you felt like it, working out when motivation was high, eating well when results came quickly) wasn't just preparation for more easy times.

It was preparation for this moment. The moment when discipline stops being optional and becomes the only thing standing between breakdown and breakthrough.

The Foundation for Everything

Every breaking point I've survived has taught me the same lesson: rock bottom is just another word for solid ground.

When everything gets stripped away (the comfort, the plans, the familiar patterns), what's left is the foundation. And if you've been building that foundation through daily discipline, through keeping promises to yourself, through choosing the hard path when the easy one beckoned, then rock bottom becomes the place you bounce back from.

But if you haven't been building that foundation, if you've been coasting on talent, or luck, or other people's support, then rock bottom becomes the place you stay.

The difference isn't intelligence, or genetics, or circumstances. It's the accumulation of small choices made in unremarkable moments that prepare you for the remarkable test's life will inevitably send.

Beyond Survival

You can survive breaking points. You can choose breakthrough over breakdown. You can use rock bottom as the foundation for everything you build next.

But surviving isn't the same as thriving. Bouncing back isn't the same as moving forward. Getting through the crisis isn't the same as becoming someone new.

That's what Part Three is about: not just surviving the resistance, but using it as fuel for transformation. Not just getting back to where you were, but becoming who you were always meant to be.

Because the real magic doesn't happen when you hit rock bottom. It happens when you decide to build something completely different on the solid ground you find there.

The discipline you've developed, the identity you've forged, the resistance you've overcome: that's not the end of the story. That's just the beginning.

The real journey starts when you stop fighting to get your old life back and start building a life so much better that you're grateful the old one had to end. That's when discipline stops being about survival and starts being about legacy.

Part 3: The Becoming

Mastery, Legacy, and Helping Others Find their Path

CHAPTER 13

Movement is Identity

Beyond the Breaking Point

Surviving resistance is just the entry fee. The real magic happens when you transform that resistance into something that outlasts you, something that changes not just your life, but every life you touch.

That push-up on the hospital carpet wasn't just about proving I could still move. It was about proving who I still was underneath the broken bones and severed tendons. Because here's what I learned in that moment: when everything external gets stripped away (the numbers you can lift, the speed you can run, the image you've built), what remains is either solid or hollow. Movement doesn't just shape your body. It reveals your soul.

Lying broken in that bed, watching my body atrophy while my mind spiraled into self-pity, I faced a choice that would define the next twenty-five years of my life: Would I be someone who did movement, or someone who *was* movement?

Most people think of exercise as something they do: a box to check, a habit to maintain, a goal to chase. But after you've been stripped down to nothing, after you've had to rebuild from broken pieces, movement becomes something deeper.

It becomes who you are.

When Everything Gets Taken Away

That nerve injury in my thirties taught me the same lesson the car accident had years earlier: your identity can be shattered in a single moment. One bad rep, one twist of the neck, and suddenly the 455-pound bench press that defined me was gone. Three hundred pounds of strength evaporated like morning mist.

I went from being "the strong guy" to struggling with 135 pounds. From training others to being the one who needed help. From confident to confused, from powerful to pathetic.

But here's what I learned in that devastation: when external achievements get stripped away, what remains is who you actually are underneath. And if you've built your identity on something deeper than numbers on a barbell, you don't just survive the setback. You use it as fuel for transformation.

The injury didn't just take away my strength. It gave me something more valuable: the understanding that movement isn't about what you can lift. It's about who you become through the process of never stopping.

The Phoenix Principle

You've heard the story: the phoenix burns to ash, then rises renewed. But here's what most people miss: the phoenix

doesn't rise because it has to. It rises because that's its nature. That's who it is.

After the injury forced me away from heavy lifting, I could have wallowed. I could have become the guy who talks about what he used to bench press. Instead, I learned to fly, literally. I got my pilot's license within a year, proving to myself that mastery is mastery, regardless of the domain.

The discipline I'd built under the barbell transferred perfectly to the cockpit. The attention to detail, the commitment to preparation, the willingness to show up regardless of conditions, none of that was tied to lifting weights. It was tied to who I'd become through lifting weights.

That's when I understood: movement doesn't just change your body. It changes your character. And character is transferable.

When You Step Back on Stage

Twenty years after that injury nearly ended everything, I walked onto a bodybuilding stage again. Not because I had something to prove to anyone else, but because I had something to prove to myself.

The audience saw the physique, the result of months of disciplined eating and training. But I felt something deeper: the character that had been forged through decades of showing up when I didn't feel like it, pushing through when progress stalled, rebuilding when everything fell apart.

Standing under those lights wasn't about validation or vindication. It was about completion: the closing of a circle

that had started with a broken kid doing one-handed push-ups on his bedroom carpet.

The real victory wasn't the competition. It was every single morning I'd chosen to get up at 3 a.m. and move, even when my shoulder screamed in protest. It was the thousands of small choices that rebuilt not just my physique, but my faith in what's possible when you refuse to stay down.

Movement as Meditation

Here's something I've never written about before: for me, movement has become a form of meditation. Not the kind where you sit and breathe, but the kind where you show up and listen.

Every morning when I descend those basement stairs at 3 a.m., I'm not just going to work out. I'm going to my purpose. The barbell becomes my sanctuary where I offer up my weakness and walk away with a little more strength. Not just physical strength (though that's part of it), but the kind of strength that helps you face whatever the day brings with humility and grit.

I think about every rep as gratitude. Gratitude for being given another day, another chance, another opportunity to be better than I was yesterday. Because movement (real, intentional movement) connects you to something bigger than yourself.

It connects you to the farmer who worked before dawn because animals depended on him. To the athlete who trained in empty gyms while others slept. To every person throughout history who understood that discipline isn't punishment. It's preparation for the life you actually want to live.

When Your Kids Are Watching

My daughter Brooklyn has seen me lift hundreds of times. But what I think sticks with her more are the mornings she's caught me stretching in silence, or journaling at the kitchen table, or just moving with intention before the day demands something from me.

She's learning that strength isn't just about how much weight you can move. It's about how you move through life: with purpose, with consistency, with the quiet confidence that comes from keeping promises to yourself.

This is the legacy I'm building. Not the trophies or the records, but the example of what it looks like to be someone who doesn't quit when life knocks you down. Someone who understands that your identity isn't what life hands you, but how you choose to face it.

The Daily Resurrection

Every morning at 3 a.m., I practice resurrection. Not the theological kind (though that matters too), but the practical kind. The daily choice to rise from whatever tried to bury you yesterday.

Some days it's physical fatigue. Some days it's emotional weight. Some days it's the accumulated stress of running a business, raising kids, being a husband, trying to be present in a world that demands constant distraction.

But the movement brings me back. Not just to my body, but to myself. To the man I chose to become when everything fell apart. To the identity I forged in fire and refuse to surrender to comfort.

That's what movement has taught me: you don't just get one shot at becoming who you're meant to be. You get a shot every single day, every time you choose discipline over drift, intention over impulse, character over comfort.

The Real Transformation

People ask me how I've stayed consistent for so long. How I keep showing up at 3 a.m. year after year. The answer isn't motivation or willpower or some secret technique.

The answer is identity.

I don't work out because I have to. I work out because that's who I am. I don't wake up early because it's healthy or productive or admirable. I wake up early because I'm the kind of person who owns his morning.

That identity wasn't born overnight. It was forged through years of small choices, tested through injuries and setbacks, refined through failures and comebacks. It was built one rep at a time, one early morning at a time, one choice at a time to be better than yesterday.

And now, at 47, I can take weight off my body like removing a jacket. Not because I'm genetically gifted or follow some secret protocol, but because twenty years of consistent movement built a metabolism and muscle base that makes transformation almost effortless.

But more importantly, those twenty years built a character that doesn't break when life gets hard. They built an identity that can weather any storm because it's not dependent on circumstances. It's dependent on choices.

What You're Really Building

Movement doesn't just shape your body. It reveals your soul. Every step, every rep, every hard-earned drop of sweat is a reminder that you're not just someone who moves. You are someone built by movement.

Built by the choice to keep going when stopping would be easier. Built by the decision to show up when motivation is nowhere to be found. Built by the understanding that greatness isn't achieved in the big moments. It's forged in the small ones, when no one's watching and no one would blame you for quitting.

Every morning, in the dark, before the world wakes up and starts making demands, you get to choose which one matters more: the person staring back at you in the mirror, or the character you're building through the choices you make.

Confidence Under Pressure

You've survived the resistance. You've learned that discipline is identity. You've discovered that movement shapes character as much as muscle.

But what happens when that character gets tested in the real world? When the confidence you've built in private has to perform in public? When the identity you've forged in solitude has to stand up under scrutiny?

That's when you discover the difference between being strong and being confident. Between having discipline and trusting yourself. Between movement as exercise and movement as the foundation for everything you become.

Because the real test isn't what you can do in the gym. It's what the gym has made you capable of doing everywhere else.

CHAPTER 14

Legacy in the Dark

When Legacy Shows Up

Jake Powell's wedding reception was winding down when he pulled me aside. Twenty-six years old now, filling out his tuxedo with the shoulders of a man who'd learned to carry weight, literally and figuratively. He looked nothing like the scrawny twelve-year-old who used to drag his feet into my gym.

"Coach," he said, gripping my hand with both of his, "I wanted to thank you. Not just for the training, but for teaching me that discipline isn't about being motivated. It's about showing up anyway."

That's when it hit me: Legacy isn't built in the spotlight. It's forged in the quiet, before the sun rises, before the accolades come, before the world opens its eyes. It happens when no one's watching and you're still choosing to do the right thing.

The hard thing. The next thing.

I called over some of the other young men I'd trained for a group photo. Noah Rummel's face lit up: "I didn't think you

remembered me." Alex Castaneda rushed over: "I need to get a picture with you for my dad."

These were the quieter kids in a group dominated by Jake and Noah Harvey, best friends since grade school who both went on to play Division I football. But seeing their faces reminded me of something fundamental: legacy isn't about the loud ones or the star athletes. It's about caring for every person who walks through your door.

Standing there with those young men (some now husbands, fathers, professionals), I realized I hadn't just been training bodies. I'd been shaping character. And they were carrying that forward into their own lives, their own families, their own spheres of influence.

The Armor We Wear

Kate walked into my gym with the kind of presence that makes you stand up straighter. Sharp wit, no-nonsense attitude, the kind of person who seemed like she could cut you down with a glance.

But here's what made me nervous: she was my old boss's wife.

Her kids had left his gym because it had become all about pushing athletes to the next level, not about building character. Too much yelling, not enough joy. They came to me, and I taught them something different: that training is a lifelong tool, not just a stepping stone. That confidence matters more than championships.

Kate watched her kids transform. Then she said she wanted to start training too.

I'll be honest: I was terrified. That brass-tacks personality made me feel like I was doing something wrong even when I wasn't. Her quick comebacks, her sharp humor. I walked on eggshells those first few weeks.

But little did I know, that armor she wore was covering up everything she'd already been through.

Divorce. Empty nest. One son overseas on classified missions with the Army Rangers. Cancer. Chronic knee pain. Decades of carrying weight (both literal and metaphorical) that she'd never had permission to put down.

Her sense of humor, those quick comebacks, that tough exterior? It was all posture. A way to keep people from seeing the pain underneath.

We started small. Not with grand transformations, but with basics. Could we get through a squat without knee pain? Could we start the day with a healthy choice instead of a sugar-loaded coffee drink? Could we move today even when everything hurt?

And slowly, the wall started coming down.

She'd mention her son in passing, the worry that lived in her chest every day he was deployed. She'd talk about the divorce, the struggle of rebuilding an identity after decades of being someone's wife and someone's mom. The weight wasn't just about food. It was about years of putting everyone else first.

That's when I realized: the discipline we were building wasn't about aesthetics. It was about reclaiming herself. Being strong enough to show up for her family when they needed her.

Three months later, she sent me a photo from Tanzania. Three people standing at the summit of Mount Kilimanjaro. Kate in the middle. Her two sons on either side. The Army Ranger home on leave. The college graduate starting his career. And their mom, strong enough to climb 19,000 feet with them.

The message was simple: "Thank you for teaching me that it's never too late to be present for the people who matter most."

A year earlier, Kate couldn't squat without pain. She was carrying decades of hurt, hiding behind armor, convinced her best days were behind her. Now she was literally on top of a mountain with her boys, creating a memory that would outlast all of them.

That's what discipline actually builds. Not just a better body. The strength to show up for the moments that matter. The presence to be there when your kids need you, not just physically, but fully.

Her sons didn't need their mom to be perfect. They needed her to be present. And that required strength she had to build one rep at a time.

The Invisible Architecture

You don't get to choose whether you have influence. You only get to choose what kind.

Every morning at 3 a.m., when I thought I was just training for myself, I was actually building something bigger. When I kept showing up after my injury, when I maintained standards even when business was slow, when I chose discipline over

comfort in a thousand small moments, I was laying bricks in a wall I couldn't see.

That wall became visible at Jake's wedding and in that photo from Kilimanjaro. In the way these young men carried themselves. In the way Kate learned to put her armor down. In the understanding that character isn't built in the big moments. It's forged in the small ones.

Legacy is the compound interest of influence. Every interaction, every standard you hold, every example you set accumulates over time until one day someone thanks you for something you don't even remember teaching them.

When Your Injury Becomes Their Inspiration

My powerlifting injury taught me something profound about legacy: sometimes your greatest influence comes not from your victories, but from how you handle your defeats.

When I went from bench pressing 455 pounds to struggling with 135, I was embarrassed. Here I was, supposedly the leader pushing everyone forward, and I'd silently closed the doors on that life in my own head. I retreated to lifting alone because I'd lost the motivation to push myself to those extremes.

But here's what I didn't see at the time: my training partners were watching. Jason and Andrew saw me get hurt, watched me struggle, observed how I chose to respond. And that became part of their story too.

Andrew channeled the intensity we'd built together into his firefighting career. He stepped up, got involved, became a

leader in his department. Now he still trains at my gym with his wife, carrying forward that discipline we'd forged together.

Jason and I started going to the pistol range when we couldn't train heavy anymore. He discovered a passion for marksmanship that became his career path. The precision, the training mindset, the dedication to improvement: everything we'd developed in the weight room transferred seamlessly to competitive shooting.

You never know how your responses to adversity will become someone else's roadmap for handling their own challenges. My injury wasn't just my setback. It became their education in resilience.

The Ripple Effect

Legacy ripples outward in ways you can't predict or control.

The shy teenager who discovers she can squat her bodyweight suddenly finds courage to speak up in other areas of her life. The businessman who rediscovers his competitive fire under the bar carries it back into his career. The mother who thought her strongest days were behind her realizes she's just getting started.

I've trained kids who became coaches themselves, passing on not just the exercises but the mindset. Adults who took the discipline they learned in my gym and applied it to their marriages, their parenting, their personal growth. Athletes who learned that showing up consistently matters more than peak performance and carried that lesson into every area of their lives.

But the ripple effect goes deeper than individual success stories. It's in the families where both parents now prioritize their health because one of them started training with me. It's in the kids who grow up seeing discipline modeled instead of just preached. It's in the community where a dozen different families are all a little stronger, a little more resilient, because someone they love learned to keep showing up.

The Responsibility of Influence

With influence comes responsibility. When people are watching (and they're always watching), every choice you make becomes a vote for the kind of world you want to create.

Do you rerack your weights when nobody's looking? Do you return your shopping cart when it's inconvenient? Do you get up at 3 a.m. and handle your business before the house wakes up? Those small actions speak louder than any speech about character.

Kids especially pick up on this. They notice whether you cut corners or stay consistent. They absorb your standards more through observation than instruction. My kids see me make my bed every morning, prep meals with intention, treat my body like it matters. They're learning that discipline isn't punishment. It's self-respect in action.

But it's not just my kids. Every athlete who trains in my gym, every client who's worked with me for years, every person who's watched me handle success and failure: they're all part of a legacy that extends far beyond any personal achievement.

Building in the Shadows

The most important work happens where no one can see it.

Every journal entry I write isn't just processing my thoughts. It's creating a record for my kids and grandkids to understand who their ancestor was, what he believed, how he handled adversity. Every early morning workout isn't just maintaining my health. It's modeling what it looks like to invest in yourself consistently over decades.

The fundraiser we ran for our local fire and rescue team raised $6,000. Not because I'm famous, but because twenty years of consistent community presence builds trust and relationships. People came out from every corner of our small town because they knew Wisconsin Barbell as a place where someone shows up every day, does the work, and cares about others.

That's what legacy looks like from the outside: not dramatic transformation or overnight success, but the quiet accumulation of trust, relationships, and reputation that comes from never missing, never making excuses, and always being where you say you'll be.

The Test of Time

Real legacy reveals itself over time. Not in the moment when you're building it, but years later when you see how it's taken root in other people's lives.

The athletes I trained at sixteen are now thirty-five with their own kids. When I reconnect with them, I can see the discipline we built together still evident in how they work, how they parent, how they approach challenges. Some fell off

track with their own health for a while (life gets complicated), but the foundation remained. Getting them back into training has been healing, not just physically but mentally.

More importantly, I watch how they raise their children. They don't demand compliance. They model consistency. They don't preach about hard work. They show up early and put in the effort. The ripple effect of what we built together decades ago is now flowing into the next generation.

What You're Actually Building

Legacy isn't what you leave behind when you die. It's what you give forward while you live.

Every morning when you choose discipline over comfort, you're not just building yourself. You're building proof of what's possible. Every time you show up when you don't feel like it, you're demonstrating to someone else that reliability is possible. Every standard you maintain, every promise you keep to yourself, every moment you choose character over convenience: someone is watching.

And that someone might be your child, learning what it means to be someone who follows through. Or your spouse, seeing what committed love actually looks like. Or a young athlete, discovering that they're capable of more than they ever imagined.

The legacy you build in the dark (in those 3 a.m. moments when no one's awake, in the daily choices that no one applauds, in the character you forge when no one would blame you for taking shortcuts), that's what echoes through eternity.

Not because you're trying to be remembered, but because you're choosing to be worthy of being followed.

Confidence in Action

You've learned that movement shapes identity and that identity shapes legacy. You've seen how the discipline built in private becomes influence that ripples outward through every relationship you touch.

But what happens when that influence gets tested? When the confidence you've built through small, daily victories has to stand up under pressure? When the identity you've forged in solitude has to perform in public?

That's when you discover the difference between borrowed confidence and earned confidence. Between reputation and character. Between knowing what you should do and trusting yourself to do it when everything is on the line.

Because the real test of legacy isn't what people say about you. It's what you've proven to yourself about who you are when no one else is watching.

CHAPTER 15

Earned Confidence

Swagger vs. Substance

There's a kid in my gym who shows up three times a week at 5:30 a.m. Never misses. Doesn't post about it on social media. Doesn't tell anyone what he's doing or why he's doing it. He just quietly gets stronger, week after week, month after month.

Then there's another guy who shows up sporadically, takes selfies between sets, and talks loudly about his goals while skipping the work that would actually achieve them.

Guess which one carries himself differently when he walks into a room?

Real confidence isn't loud. It doesn't need validation. It doesn't require an audience. It's earned in the dark, one promise kept to yourself at a time.

This is what most people get wrong about confidence. They think it's about feeling good about yourself. But that's just positive thinking wearing a disguise. True confidence is about

knowing what you're capable of because you've proven it to yourself repeatedly, when no one was watching and no one was cheering.

It's the difference between swagger and substance. Between hype and hope. Between talking the talk and walking the walk until your legs are strong enough to carry you anywhere you want to go.

The 3 a.m. Test

I learned what real confidence was the morning after I'd lost 300 pounds off my bench press.

My shoulder was screaming. My ego was shattered. Everything I thought I knew about myself had been stripped away in one careless moment. I could have stayed in bed. I could have felt sorry for myself. I could have used my injury as an excuse to quit.

Instead, I got up at 3 a.m. and went to my gym.

Not because I felt confident. Because I needed to prove to myself that I was still the kind of person who shows up. Not for the weight I could lift (that was gone). Not for how I looked (that would take months to rebuild). But for the promise I'd made to myself years earlier: no matter what happens, I don't quit.

That morning, doing rehab exercises with five-pound dumbbells, I discovered something profound: confidence isn't about what you can do when you're at your best. It's about what you choose to do when you're at your worst.

The weight room was empty except for me and my broken shoulder. No one to impress. No one to prove anything to.

Just me and the choice to honor the commitment I'd made to myself.

That's when I realized confidence isn't a feeling. It's a decision. The decision to keep the promises you make to yourself, especially when it's hard. Especially when no one would blame you for breaking them.

What Early Mornings Actually Build

People think I get up at 3 a.m. to work out. But the workout is just the vehicle. What I'm really building is trust with myself.

Every morning I choose discipline over comfort, I'm making a deposit in the bank account of my self-respect. Every time I show up when I don't feel like it, I'm proving to myself that I'm reliable. That I'm the kind of person who follows through. That my word (even to myself) means something.

That's what creates unshakeable confidence: the accumulated evidence that you can count on yourself. When you know (not think, not hope, but *know*) that you'll show up for yourself regardless of circumstances, you develop a quiet inner strength that doesn't fluctuate with your mood or your situation.

But this didn't happen overnight. I wasn't born with some natural ability to wake up before dawn and love every minute of it. This was built through thousands of small wins, many failures, and the gradual understanding that confidence doesn't just happen. It has to be earned.

I remember my first attempts at early morning training. I'd set the alarm for 4:30 a.m. and hit snooze until 5:30. I'd feel

guilty all day, promising myself I'd do better tomorrow. Then I'd repeat the same cycle. For weeks.

That's when I learned that confidence isn't built through perfect execution. It's built through the willingness to start again. To take the small win when you can't get the big one. To celebrate getting up at 5:30 when your goal was 5 a.m., because 5:30 is still earlier than 6, and earlier than 6 is still movement in the right direction.

I had to nurture this habit like a fragile seedling. Some mornings, "success" was just putting my feet on the floor when the alarm went off, even if I went back to bed. Other mornings, it was getting dressed in workout clothes, even if I didn't make it to the gym. I learned to take credit for the small movements toward my goal rather than punishing myself for not achieving perfection immediately.

The Conversation You Have With Yourself

I learned about this internal conversation watching *Pumping Iron* as a kid. There's a moment that stuck with me for decades: Arnold Schwarzenegger learned that his father had died, but chose to stay focused on the Mr. Olympia competition instead of flying home immediately.

People criticized him for it. Called him cold. Heartless. But Arnold understood something most people don't: there are moments in life when discipline isn't just about building character. It's about honoring the character you've already built.

Years later, I found myself standing in my kitchen at 4:45 a.m. during one of the hardest periods of my life, staring at my gym bag and having that same argument with myself.

The voice of comfort said: *Everything's falling apart. No one expects you to work out today. Give yourself a break.*

The voice of discipline said: *This is exactly when you need to show up. This is when it matters most.*

I went to the gym.

Not because I felt like it. Not because I was motivated. But because I'd learned that the most important conversation you have each day is the one you have with yourself in those vulnerable moments when comfort and discipline are fighting for control.

Every time you choose discipline in that conversation, you're building evidence that you're someone who can be trusted to do the right thing, even when it's hard. Every time you choose comfort, you're building evidence that you'll fold when things get tough.

Your confidence is built on the cumulative weight of those choices.

Real Confidence Is Quiet

I can spot real confidence from across a room. It's not the person talking the loudest or posting the most. It's not the one who needs to tell everyone about their accomplishments or their goals.

Real confidence is quiet because it doesn't need external validation. It knows what it's built on, and it knows that foundation is solid.

I think about Jake Powell at his wedding, thanking me for teaching him that discipline isn't about motivation. There was

something in his posture, his handshake, the way he looked me in the eye. This wasn't a kid trying to prove something anymore. This was a man who'd proven things to himself.

That's what years of consistent action builds: the kind of confidence that doesn't need to announce itself because it's secure in what it's accomplished and what it's capable of.

Compare that to the people who are always talking about what they're going to do, what they're planning, what their goals are. All talk, no substance. All volume, no depth. That's not confidence. That's insecurity trying to convince itself it's something more.

Real confidence shows up in how you carry yourself when you think no one is looking. It's in the calm way you handle unexpected problems. It's in your willingness to admit when you don't know something because you're secure enough in what you do know.

The Compound Interest of Small Wins

Confidence works like compound interest. It's built through small, consistent deposits that seem insignificant at the time but create enormous returns over time.

Making your bed every morning? That's a small deposit. Showing up to the gym when you don't feel like it? Another deposit. Having the difficult conversation instead of avoiding it? Deposit. Writing in your journal when you'd rather scroll your phone? Deposit. Choosing the harder path when the easier one beckons? Deposit.

None of these things feel significant in the moment. But over time, they create an account of self-trust that generates massive returns when you need to draw on it.

I learned this during my darkest period after the injury. When I couldn't rely on my strength anymore, I had to rely on my character. When I couldn't lift heavy weights, I had to lift my own spirits. When I couldn't impress others with my performance, I had to rely on the confidence I'd built through years of small, consistent actions.

Those daily deposits (years of getting up early, years of doing the work when no one was watching, years of keeping promises to myself), that's what carried me through. Not motivation. Not inspiration. Not external encouragement. The accumulated evidence that I was someone who didn't quit.

When Confidence Gets Tested

Real confidence isn't revealed when things are going well. It's revealed when everything falls apart and you still show up.

When I was sitting in that cockpit learning to fly, three weeks after my injury had shattered everything I thought I knew about myself, I wasn't feeling confident. I was feeling broken, lost, searching for something to prove I still had value.

But here's what I discovered: confidence isn't the absence of doubt. It's the willingness to act in spite of doubt.

Every flying lesson was terrifying. Every takeoff was an exercise in trusting systems I didn't fully understand. Every landing was a test of my ability to stay calm under pressure. But I kept showing up because I'd built a foundation of self-

trust strong enough to support me even when I couldn't see the outcome.

That's when I realized that confidence and fear aren't opposites. They can coexist. The confident person isn't fearless. They're someone who's proven to themselves that they can handle fear and keep moving forward anyway.

Building Your Daily Evidence

Here's what real confidence looks like in daily practice:

Morning Evidence:

- I got up when I said I would, not when I felt like it.
- I did my first important task before checking my phone.
- I chose discipline over comfort in the first hour of my day.

Character Evidence:

- I had the difficult conversation instead of avoiding it.
- I kept a promise to myself that only I knew about.
- I chose the harder right over the easier wrong.

Physical Evidence:

- I moved my body intentionally, even if briefly.
- I honored my commitments to my health.
- I treated my body like it matters.

This isn't about perfection. It's about building a daily practice of proving to yourself that you're reliable, that your word

means something, that you can be trusted to do what you say you'll do.

The Confidence That Carries You

When I stepped back onto that bodybuilding stage, I wasn't confident because of how I looked or what I could lift. I was confident because of who I'd become in the process of getting there.

Every morning I'd chosen to get up early. Every workout where I'd done what I could instead of mourning what I couldn't do. Every day I'd stayed committed to becoming someone worth believing in: that's what carried me onto that stage.

The audience saw the physique. I felt the character.

That's what real confidence is: the quiet knowledge that you've done the work, you've kept the promises, you've shown up consistently enough to trust yourself with whatever comes next.

The Inevitable Break

You've learned that confidence comes from evidence, not feelings. That self-trust is built through small, daily promises kept to yourself. That real confidence is quiet because it doesn't need external validation. It knows what it's built on.

But what happens when that confidence gets tested by life's inevitable setbacks? When the discipline you've built and the trust you've earned face circumstances that threaten to break them both?

That's when you discover the difference between confidence and resilience. Between trusting yourself in good times and trusting your ability to handle whatever comes. Between having strength and having the flexibility to bend without breaking.

Because the real test of earned confidence isn't whether you can succeed when everything goes according to plan. It's whether you can trust yourself to find a way forward when nothing does.

CHAPTER 16

When Discipline Breaks

The Hardest Truth to Face

I stared at this blank page for weeks. Not because I didn't have material (God knows I've got plenty of setbacks to choose from). But because writing about discipline breaking feels like admitting weakness. Like pulling back the curtain on the myth that if you just wake up early enough, work hard enough, stay disciplined enough, life won't knock you flat on your back.

But that's exactly why this chapter needs to exist. Because discipline isn't about avoiding setbacks. It's about what you do when they come. And they always come.

Here's the truth most motivational speakers won't tell you: discipline doesn't make you immune to failure. It doesn't protect you from injury, job loss, relationship crisis, or any of the thousand ways life can derail your best-laid plans.

What discipline does is prepare you to handle the derailment differently. Not to avoid the crash, but to walk away from it stronger.

When Everything Falls Apart at Once

Some setbacks announce themselves with the screech of brakes and the crunch of metal. My car accident took away a season of football: what turned out to be one of the best seasons in UW-Eau Claire history. I watched from the sidelines as my teammates lived the dream I trained years to be part of.

Other setbacks creep up slowly, like the highlighted apartment ads I found scattered around our place during grad school. Seven years into our relationship, and suddenly she wanted out. I was living on a $500-a-month stipend, walking everywhere because I couldn't afford a car. The relationship that had been my anchor was pulling up stakes and sailing away.

But here's what I learned from both experiences: external setbacks, even devastating ones, don't break discipline. They test it. They reveal whether what you've built is real or just a house of cards waiting for the first strong wind.

The car accident that ended my football career led me to discover strength training as more than just preparation for sports. The breakup that shattered my seven-year relationship taught me I could thrive on my own and eventually led me to my wife.

Setbacks aren't interruptions to your discipline. They're the curriculum.

The Internal Crossroads

External setbacks are actually easier to handle than internal ones. A car accident gives you something concrete to fight

against. But what happens when the enemy is your own doubt, your own comfort, your own success?

After eighteen years of running Wisconsin Barbell, I hit an internal crossroads I never saw coming. Not because the gym was failing. It was successful beyond what I'd imagined when I started. But because success brings its own problems.

My client base was aging. The retirees who'd been with me for decades were moving to Florida or cutting back on training. The young athletes needed different hours than my loyal long-timers. I was caught between loyalty to the people who built this place with me and the reality that my own life was changing.

My kids were getting older. I wanted to be at their games, help coach their teams, be present for the moments that matter. But I'd built a business that required me to be everywhere, all the time.

Here's the internal crossroads: I knew exactly what I needed to do. Raise rates. Cut some evening hours. Hire help and delegate. I've read the books, done the math, written the plan on paper. But I couldn't pull the trigger.

Why? Because raising rates meant some people might leave. And even though I knew intellectually that most would stay and I'd make more money working fewer hours, the thought of losing anyone who'd been part of this journey felt like betrayal.

When Success Becomes the Enemy

For years, I'd prided myself on never raising prices. Eighteen years of inflation, and I was still charging what I charged in

2007. I told myself it was about staying true to my values, not wanting to turn anyone away because of money.

Really, it was fear. Fear of conflict. Fear of change. Fear of discovering that my relationships with clients were more transactional than I wanted to believe.

It feels like I'm doing the same thing for eighteen years and still living paycheck to paycheck. I'm saving money yet still scraping by, and now when big things come up (needing a new roof for $20,000, major plumbing issues at my rental for $15,000, buying a car for $15,000 cash borrowed from a friend that I still haven't paid back), all of a sudden I'm $50,000 in debt.

What was once manageable where I could have a few extra bucks became maxing out credit cards and slowly paying down interest. I keep telling myself this is just a phase, or everything comes in threes, but I'm about to break.

When I try to bring up money with clients, my head gets a tingle through every hair on it. My hands get nervous, my hair stands on edge, my voice cracks. I'm somewhere between "I can't do this anymore" and "You gotta help me out," and I don't want to admit I need help.

The physical sensation of that resentment building was suffocating. When clients walked in late, I'd grumble and put on a face that said "Hey, good to see you, you're twenty minutes late" and laugh it off. In the back of my head I'd swallow it and say, "It's okay, they're late, but I'll still be here." That client was getting personal training rates at group training levels.

Over the past year, I wanted to shut the music off and yell, "Hey, everybody listen up!" and go on my soapbox. But I can't. I didn't.

The people-pleasing version of myself (the one I thought I'd killed years earlier) was still alive, whispering his familiar lies: "They'll leave if you raise prices. They won't understand. You'll lose everything you've built."

But staying stuck in 2007 pricing was killing me slowly. I was resentful, exhausted, angry. The very kindness I thought I was showing was turning me bitter.

The Writing on the Wall

The difference between those who recover from setbacks and those who don't isn't talent, genetics, or even circumstances. It's the ability to read the writing on the wall before the wall falls on you.

I've watched successful business owners come to me during the pandemic, scrambling for side jobs because their vacation-based businesses evaporated overnight. I've held tissues for women going through divorces who were convinced they weren't worthy of love because their ex-husbands convinced them their weight was the problem.

The ones who bounce back fastest aren't the ones who never saw it coming. They're the ones who, when reality hit, asked themselves one question: "How long is my pity party going to last?"

Three days? Three weeks? Three months? Because at some point, you have to choose yourself again. You have to plant

your flag in the ground and decide who you're going to be moving forward.

Discipline Doesn't Break. It Bends

Here's what twenty-five years of setbacks have taught me: discipline doesn't actually break. It bends. It flexes. It adapts. But the core remains.

When my relationship ended, I didn't stop training. I redirected the energy. When my car accident derailed football, I didn't give up on fitness. I found new goals. When the nerve injury took away heavy weight training, I didn't abandon everything I'd built. I evolved.

The key is to keep progressing. Don’t build walls that block your growth. Learn from your past and build bridges toward your future. A bridge reminds you that you’ve moved from where you started, but it also lets you carry the lessons forward. It connects who you were to who you’re still becoming.

When I finally raised my prices in 2025, it wasn't because I'd become greedy or forgotten my values. It was because I'd learned to distinguish between serving people and enabling them. Between being kind and being a doormat. Between loyalty and self-destruction.

Most clients didn't even blink at the increase. The few who left? They probably should have left years earlier. What remained was a stronger foundation: clients who valued what I offered, who respected boundaries, who wanted to be part of something intentional rather than chaotic.

When Discipline Becomes a Lifeline

The call came on a Tuesday. Mike had been one of my first athletes twenty years ago: sixteen years old, all energy and potential. I'd watched him grow into a Marine, stood at his wedding fifteen years ago, celebrated when his boys were born.

Now he was sitting across from me in my gym, and I barely recognized him. The confident young man who'd once dominated high school football looked broken. Hollow.

"My wife is leaving me," he said, the words falling like stones into the silence between us.

I felt that familiar knife twist in my chest, the one that comes when you see someone you care about drowning and you're not sure you can throw them a life preserver without going under yourself.

Mike had been struggling financially for months. Traveling constantly for work, barely scraping by, trying to hold his family together. He'd been training sporadically, knowing he needed to drop weight but unable to afford consistent sessions. I'd been giving him deals, working around his schedule, because that's what you do for people who've become family.

But here's the thing about being a business owner who cares too much: every exception you make for one person means turning away someone else who'd pay full price. I'd been explaining my new pricing structure, trying to create boundaries that would save my sanity and my business. Mike and his buddy could move to later times, make it work somehow.

Then he looked at me with those broken Marine eyes and said the words I'll never forget: "Don't take this away from me. I need this."

The gym wasn't just about losing weight for him. It was his anchor. His proof that he could still fight when everything else was falling apart. The one place where he could remember who he used to be and maybe find his way back to that man.

I saw myself in that moment. The kid who'd needed one functional push-up on a shag carpet to prove he wasn't done. The man who'd rebuilt his entire identity after losing his strength. The father who'd learned that sometimes taking care of yourself isn't selfish. It's the only way you can take care of anyone else.

We figured out how to make it work. Because that's what you do when someone's discipline is breaking and they're reaching for anything solid to hold onto. You become that solid thing.

But watching Mike fight to save himself while his marriage crumbled taught me about the breaking point: sometimes your discipline doesn't just break personally. Sometimes life attacks the very relationships and anchors that discipline helped you build. And in those moments, the community you've created through years of showing up becomes the difference between breakdown and breakthrough.

Mike needed the gym like a drowning man needs air. Not because it would fix his marriage or solve his financial problems, but because it would prove to himself (and to his sons) that he was still the kind of man who doesn't quit when things get difficult.

That's what discipline really builds over time: not just personal strength, but a network of people who understand that strength. Who know what it costs to show up when you don't feel like it. Who recognize the look in someone's eyes when they're holding onto their last thread of hope.

It takes a lot for a Marine to ask for help. Just like it takes a lot for me to admit when I'm struggling. But that's where real discipline is tested: not in the motivation to start, but in the vulnerability to keep going when everything is falling apart.

The Comeback Mindset

I don't have "setbacks" anymore. I have comebacks. Because every time life knocks me down, I've learned that I don't just get back to where I was. I get to where I was supposed to be.

The car accident that almost ended my college football career led me to discover strength training as a lifelong passion. The breakup that shattered my seven-year relationship taught me independence and eventually led me to my wife. The business challenges I faced pushed me to become a better leader, a more strategic thinker, a more present father.

This isn't positive thinking or silver-lining nonsense. It's pattern recognition. When you've survived enough setbacks, you start to see them not as random disasters but as course corrections. Not as punishment but as preparation.

The discipline you build in the good times isn't just for more good times. It's preparation for everything. It's the foundation that lets you bend without breaking. It’s the foundation that requires you to adapt without losing your core. It’s the foundation that makes your comeback stronger than you were before.

When Everything Feels Lost

There will be moments when everything feels lost. When the discipline you've built feels pointless, when the progress you've made seems invisible, when the person you've become feels like a stranger even to yourself.

These aren't signs that your discipline has broken. They're signs that it's being tested at a level you've never experienced before.

The question isn't whether you'll face these moments. You will. The question is: when they come, who will you choose to become?

Because setbacks don't break disciplined people. They reveal them. In the space between getting knocked down and getting back up, you discover what you're actually made of.

And if you've spent years building discipline through small, daily choices, if you've proven to yourself repeatedly that you're someone who keeps showing up, then you already know the answer.

You're someone who doesn't stay down.

The Next Generation

You can survive setbacks. You can push through doubt, business slowdowns, relationship tension, and physical limitations. You can become the kind of person who sees obstacles as curriculum and comebacks as inevitable.

But surviving your own setbacks is only half the story. What happens when the people you care about most (your children,

your athletes, the next generation) need to learn these same lessons?

How do you pass on discipline without passing on your baggage? How do you teach resilience without creating pressure? How do you model strength while admitting vulnerability?

That's when you discover that the greatest test of your discipline isn't what it does for you. It's what it does for the people watching you, learning from you, following the path you're cutting through the darkness.

CHAPTER 17

Teaching the Next Generation

The 3 a.m. Question

It was 3 a.m. when I woke her up for a quick potty break, her eyes half open and her voice soft. As I tucked her back into bed, she looked up at me and asked, "Is this morning for you, and for me is it night?"

We'd talked about it the night before. She'd asked, "Daddy, are you going to wake me up in the middle of the night?" I told her, "Yes honey, but for Daddy, I have to go to work and work out, so it's morning."

When she asked me that question after I put her back in bed, I smiled and gave her a kiss on the forehead. It melted my heart and I walked away choked up from the love I felt from her little voice half asleep.

She'd been watching me get up at this hour every single day for months, and somehow she'd internalized my routine so completely that 3 a.m. wasn't just "the middle of the night" to her. It was "Daddy's morning." I immediately wrote down that note in my phone: "Brooklyn asked if it was my morning and her night this morning. I laughed and said yes, Daddy is

going to workout and work. I love this girl so much and want to show her that what I am doing is for our family and for her."

That simple question stopped me in my tracks. Here was my four-year-old daughter, half-asleep in the dark, and she understood exactly what time it was. Not because she could read a clock, but because she'd been watching me choose discipline over comfort every single day.

Her words lingered after I tucked her in. Kids have a way of asking questions that cut straight through all the noise. It made me think about how my world looks through her eyes. The lines between early mornings, long days, and late nights must blur together into one big picture of Dad always working.

I felt like I was on the right path. This is what I'm supposed to be doing. But there's a fine line between work and play, one they don't yet understand. When I go into my office in the basement, they think Dad is working. Between writing, programming, coding, and using my Cricut to make them shirts with unicorns and dragons, I'm actually playing down there. Still, I have to remind myself to step away from the screen and go watch them swing on the gymnastics bar. I don't want them to remember me as someone who was always working. I want them to see that all this work is what allows me to show up for them.

From Stadium Lights to Inner Fire

I remember the rush of walking onto a football field with eighty other guys all chasing the same mission. There's something powerful about that kind of brotherhood, that

sense of belonging to something bigger than yourself. Team sports teach you what it feels like to have others counting on you, to be part of a shared struggle.

But here's what I learned: when the crowd goes home and the season ends, that external energy doesn't automatically carry over into the rest of your life. Unless you're the guy living in the past, wearing his letterman jacket at forty, what really matters is the individual discipline you build for yourself.

That's where wrestling and track come in. They don't carry the glamor of football: no 80,000 fans, no highlight reels on ESPN every week, but the individual reward is often greater. As Tom Ryan writes in *Chosen Suffering*, wrestling teaches you to willingly embrace pain and sacrifice, because no one else can step on the mat for you.

Ben Askren captured this in *Funky*: he never fit the traditional athlete mold, but he thrived because he leaned into his individuality. Wrestling gave him the freedom to express that uniqueness, where it doesn't matter how you look or if your style is conventional. What matters is whether you can outlast and outthink the person in front of you.

That's the lesson I try to pass on: teach kids the value of being part of something bigger, yes. But also show them how to develop that inner engine that doesn't need a stadium full of fans to keep running. Because discipline that lasts isn't built on the roar of the crowd. It's built on the quiet decision to keep moving when no one is watching.

Teaching Systems, Not Compliance

My friend Dr. Scott Allen, Psy.D, says it perfectly: it only takes one decision to become disciplined at something. You either do it or you don't. But what I've found, especially with kids, is that discipline grows stronger when you teach them systems rather than just demand compliance.

Take the weight room. You don't walk in and start throwing heavy weight around. If you want to build strength correctly, you start with the basics. Foam roll those tight muscles. Dynamic warm-up. Activation drills for glutes, hips, mobility. Only after all that preparation are you ready for loaded movements.

Skip that process, and you set yourself up for discouragement or injury. Can't squat without your heels coming up? Can't front squat without your elbows dropping? That's not because you "aren't strong enough." It's because you ignored the system.

This isn't just a weight room lesson. It's how discipline is built in any domain. I'm a third-degree black belt, and even now I go back to the seven mandatory kicks over and over again. Some new instructors want to give higher belts flashy routines, but the truth is that mastery isn't about tricks. It's about refinement.

As Bruce Lee said: "I fear not the man who has practiced 10,000 kicks once, but I fear the man who has practiced one kick 10,000 times."

That's the essence of discipline. Not demanding compliance with drill-sergeant authority, but showing kids that greatness

is found in systems, in consistency, in the decision to do simple things over and over until they become second nature.

When Talent Meets Discipline

In twenty-five years of coaching, I've seen raw talent rise all the way to professional levels, and I've watched the same kind of talent flicker out like a candle: bright for a moment, then gone. That doesn't mean those kids didn't go on to live good lives, but the pedestal they were placed on can be dangerous when talent isn't matched with discipline.

My job has never been just about writing training programs. It's about helping athletes discover their personal "why." Motivation is the carrot I can dangle in front of them to get them moving. But the ultimate goal is for them to take that carrot and put it in their own pocket, carrying it forward because they've internalized the drive.

Kai Greene, a professional bodybuilder who was second at Mr. Olympia to Phil Heath would say, "Hard work beats talent when talent doesn't work hard." That's the lesson I want every kid to walk away with. Talent may open the door, but discipline is what keeps you in the room. Although Kai finished second, he is remembered as one of the greatest artistic posers and bodybuilders of the 2010 era.

I want the young athletes to fall in love with the process: the early mornings, the basics, the grind that slowly builds the kind of discipline that outlasts the spotlight. Because when the cheers fade and the "next big thing" title moves on to someone else, discipline is the only thing that will keep them coming back for more.

Your Kids Are Watching Everything

When kids are twelve to fourteen, they hang on your every word as an athletic performance trainer. Tell them to warm up. Do their glute extensions. Run through drills. They line up like little soldiers and get it done. They're still absorbing, still building the foundation.

But something shifts around sophomore year. By then, they've learned the basics. They don't need someone barking commands as much as they need refinement, nuance, and a living example to follow.

That's why I still do the training programs I put my athletes through. At 47, I figure I've got another forty years to keep up this pace, and I don't want to coach from the sidelines of theory. This past summer I was on the platform with three of my college athletes, pulling cleans right alongside them. I wanted to see if I could still hang, and more importantly, I wanted them to see me do it.

Because appreciation runs deeper when your athletes see you live it. "Do as I do" always beats "do as I say." People are always watching, especially the people you lead.

It's the same principle everywhere. Do you rerack your weights? Do you return your shopping cart when no one's looking? Do you get up at 3 a.m. and handle your business before the house wakes up? Those small actions speak louder than the biggest speeches.

Kids pick up on everything. They notice whether you cut corners or stay consistent. More than anything you tell them; they'll carry the example of what you actually do.

The Foundation Starts Early

My wife started teaching our kids how to make their beds at five and six years old. It's a great start, and I see how proud they are when they do it well. I give them large amounts of praise, and our daughter, who likes things aligned, is much better at it than her twin brother. He's the type to just throw the blanket over messy sheets, and that's okay. It's still a teaching process that will improve with time.

The morning routine we're building starts simple: wake up, go potty, brush teeth, put clothes on, brush and comb hair, then head downstairs. They're only five and six, so I could sit here and plan the next ten years, but that would blow up in frustration. You need a goal as a guide, but flexibility in execution. Some days won't work out perfectly, and that's not failure. It's learning.

The balance between pushing and supporting starts with getting yourself up first and doing what you need to do. If you're always late, always frantic, always rushed, you have no bandwidth to support anyone else. Self-care becomes the foundation for caring for others. This is where ownership comes into play.

When Discipline Is Caught, Not Taught

Our boy is always the first one up. He loves playing his games or tossing a ball around first thing in the morning. And he gets that time because mom and dad handle our business before the kids wake up. Owning our morning gives our kids the opportunity to own theirs and do what they want at their own version of "3 a.m."

When we all wake up at the same time, breakfast isn't ready, clothes aren't set out, and we're fighting for survival instead of operating from skill. But when we handle our needs first, there's space for our son to handle his. Time for our daughter to practice making her bed just right. Room for them to discover their own version of discipline, their own reasons for getting up and getting after it.

That's the goal: not to create little robots who follow orders, but to raise kids who understand that discipline is freedom. Freedom to pursue what matters to them. Freedom to fail safely while building their own systems. Freedom to become the kind of adults who carry their own fire.

Building Character, Not Just Compliance

Being a personal trainer for thousands of clients over twenty-five years has proven that discipline works, but it starts from the top down. You can't be a hard-nosed, discipline-expecting parent if you're not disciplined yourself.

And discipline comes in many forms. Yes, I've seen parents who never miss a workout, but I've also seen parents whose greatest discipline is how they treat their spouse. In today's world, staying happily married (truly loving your husband or wife) is one of the hardest disciplines to practice.

It's showing up for each other when it's inconvenient, speaking with kindness when you don't feel like it, choosing commitment over comfort every single day. Kids watch that more than you think. They notice if you speak with respect or roll your eyes. They feel the steadiness in a home where love is guarded like treasure.

That's the kind of discipline that seeps into them for life, not because you told them, but because they saw it lived out in front of them.

The Long Game

The athletes I trained at sixteen are now thirty-five with their own kids. When I reconnect with them after years apart, I can see the discipline we built together still evident in how they work, how they parent, how they approach challenges.

More importantly, I watch how they raise their children. They don't demand compliance from their kids. They model consistency. They don't preach about hard work. They show up early and put in the effort. The ripple effect of what we built together decades ago is now flowing into the next generation.

I want to teach my kids that respect is earned, not given. The more disciplined and confident they become in their decisions, the more they'll show the kind of respect that comes from wanting to lead, not just follow.

What You're Really Teaching

When you get up at 3 a.m. and move your body with intention, you're not just working out. You're showing the next generation what it looks like to invest in yourself. When you prep meals on Sunday, you're teaching them that success requires preparation. When you go to bed early so you can show up fully tomorrow, you're modeling the connection between choices and consequences.

These aren't lectures about discipline. These are demonstrations of what a disciplined life actually looks like.

And the beautiful thing? Kids don't need you to be perfect. They need you to be consistent. They need to see that when you fall off track, you get back on. That when you make mistakes, you own them and adjust.

They're learning that discipline isn't about being rigid or joyless. It's about having the freedom to live the life you actually want instead of just reacting to whatever life throws at you.

When It Multiplies

You've learned to model discipline instead of just preaching it. You've discovered that kids catch character more than they're taught it. You understand that the next generation learns more from watching your consistency than listening to your advice.

But what happens when those small, daily examples accumulate over years and decades? When the discipline you've modeled and the character you've built start compounding not just in your own life, but in the lives of everyone you've influenced?

That's when you discover that discipline isn't just personal development. It's generational transformation. That the choices you make in the dark don't just shape you. They shape the future through every person who's been watching, learning, and carrying your example forward.

Because the real measure of discipline isn't what it does for you. It's what it does for the world through the people you've helped become who they were meant to be.

CHAPTER 18

The Compound Effect

Calculating the Compound

The numbers are staggering when you actually calculate them out.

Twenty years. Three hundred training days per year. Two extra hours each morning before the world wakes up. That's 12,000 hours of "found time": time that didn't exist before I made the decision to get up at 3 a.m.

Twelve thousand hours. That's enough time to master multiple skills, build a business, write several books, transform your body completely, deepen relationships, or change your entire life trajectory. It's the equivalent of working a full-time job for six straight years.

But here's what I've learned: the compound effect isn't really about the hours. It's about what happens to you during those hours. It's about the person you become when you consistently choose discipline over comfort, purpose over impulse, delayed gratification over instant relief.

After two decades of 3 a.m. mornings, I can take weight off my body like removing a jacket. Not because I'm genetically gifted or follow some secret protocol, but because twenty years of consistent training built a metabolism and muscle base that makes fat loss almost effortless.

Most people who lose weight struggle to keep it off because they approach it like wringing out a wet sponge: lighter, but still fundamentally the same sponge. What I built was different architecture entirely.

The Foundation Years

It started on my uncle's dairy farm in high school. The local gym opened at 8 a.m., which gave me just enough time to help with morning milking, shower quickly, and drive fifteen minutes to train before heading back for afternoon chores.

I could have stayed home after milking, taken a nap, eaten breakfast, started my day like a normal teenager. Instead, I chose those silent drives: fifteen minutes each way to think, plan and visualize the workout ahead. That was my first taste of what I now recognize as sacred time, even if I didn't have the words for it yet.

After training with friends, we'd return to farm work completely energized and ready to attack the day. That time was ours. No one else's agenda. No distractions. Just us, the iron, and the quiet satisfaction of having done something for ourselves before the world woke up.

That pattern followed me through college, graduate school, and into my career. Even when I only had to work eight hours a day (which felt like vacation compared to farming

and graduate school), I was so accustomed to early training that I found myself with extra energy and time.

I earned my black belt in Taekwondo in two years during this period. Something I'd always wanted to do but "never had time for" as a kid. The discipline of 3 a.m. didn't just give me time. It gave me the mental capacity to use that time effectively.

The Business Built on Reliability

I can count on one hand how many times I've overslept and unintentionally missed training at my gym in eighteen years. Three times. Every occurrence was alcohol-influenced: staying up too late, making choices that conflicted with my morning commitment.

Those rare failures taught me that you can't build a reputation on discipline while living an undisciplined life outside the gym. The shift from college party mindset to responsible leadership mindset wasn't just about avoiding hangovers. It was about understanding that consistency requires alignment across all areas of your life.

My clients began to notice. They'd comment on my energy at 3 p.m., amazed that I maintained the same intensity throughout the day. What they didn't see was that by the time they arrived, I'd already been awake and active for twelve hours. The real energy came from starting each day on my own terms, with my priorities handled before anyone else's needs entered the picture.

This consistency built Wisconsin Barbell. Not flashy marketing or cutting-edge equipment, but the simple reliability of a coach who shows up every single day. Who

does the work alongside his clients. Who can be counted on regardless of weather, mood, or circumstances.

Over twenty years, I've watched six other gyms within a mile radius open and close. The ones that survived were run by owners who understood that consistency isn't just a business strategy. It's a way of life. The ones that failed were operated by people who thought enthusiasm could substitute for discipline.

Client loyalty that spans decades doesn't come from being the most knowledgeable trainer or having the best facility. It comes from being trustworthy. From never missing, never making excuses, never letting personal problems become your clients' problems.

When you've shown up for someone for twenty years (through their divorces, job changes, health scares, and family crises), you become more than their trainer. You are an important and valued person in their life. You become proof that consistency is possible in an inconsistent world.

The Physical Dividend

The injuries came early and often throughout my athletic career. Each setback taught me that most limitations exist in our heads, not our bodies. But more importantly, they taught me that learning to work through and around obstacles builds mental capacity for handling any kind of adversity.

That resilience has compound returns. At 47, I can keep up with my kids in ways most dads can't. I can still compete in martial arts, lift meaningful weight, and have the energy to be present for the people who matter most. Not because I

avoided injuries, but because I learned to work through and around them.

The compound effect of physical discipline isn't just about looking good or being strong. It's about building a body and mind that can handle whatever life throws at you, then getting back up to face the next challenge.

But here's the real magic: when your physical foundation is solid, everything else gets easier. Decision-making improves when your blood sugar is stable. Emotional regulation improves when you've released stress through movement. Confidence improves when you've already accomplished something difficult before breakfast.

The Relationship Transformation

Waking up at 3 a.m. made me a better husband and father, though not in the way most people expect.

Early rising doesn't automatically make you a better person. But it gives you the space to become one. When I handle my training, writing, and personal development before the house wakes up, I'm not rushed or stressed during family time. I'm not mentally occupied with my to-do list while my kids are trying to get my attention.

Brooklyn's sleepy 3 a.m. question ("Is this morning for you, and for me is it night?") perfectly captured this balance. She understood that 3 a.m. was Daddy's time, but that I'd still take care of her needs first. That's what discipline creates: the ability to be fully present because you've already taken care of yourself.

Being present for your kids when you're not rushed or stressed is completely different from being there physically while mentally somewhere else. Instead of saying "Not now, Daddy's working," I can say "Yes" because I've already done my work.

This extends to financial decisions too. While my wife doesn't always understand why I stress about maxing out retirement accounts each year, I know the fruit will be harvested from seeds planted decades earlier. It's the marshmallow test in adult form: choosing delayed gratification over immediate comfort, trusting that consistency compounds in ways you can't see in the moment.

The Mental and Emotional Compound

The confidence that comes from keeping promises to yourself is perhaps the most valuable compound effect of all. When you prove to yourself daily that you can wake up when you say you will, train when you don't feel like it, and stick to your standards when it would be easier to quit, you begin expecting that level of reliability from yourself in every area.

This creates a natural filtering effect in your relationships. You start gravitating toward people who share similar values around consistency and follow-through. You become less tolerant of excuses and more appreciative of those who simply show up and do the work.

The quiet morning hours provide problem-solving clarity that's impossible to find during the chaos of daily life. Your mind has space to process without constant input from phones, conversations, and external demands. Solutions

emerge naturally when you give your subconscious room to work.

Emotional stability becomes your family's bedrock. My kids know that when I say something, I mean it. They get one warning, not three. This isn't harshness. It's reliability. When boundaries don't shift based on mood or circumstance, children feel more secure, not less.

This extends to unexpected challenges. The 3 a.m. emergency calls, middle-of-the-night accidents, crying babies: these don't feel like disruptions when you've been awake for thirty minutes already. They feel manageable. Expected, even. You develop the peace that comes from knowing you can handle whatever comes.

The Stories You Collect

For over a decade now, I've kept detailed journals tracking everything from training progressions to business insights to family moments. What started as record-keeping has become family legacy: pages of notes about overcoming obstacles, trying new approaches, failing, adapting, and eventually succeeding.

This documentation isn't just for me. I'm building this for my kids, for future generations who will wonder what their ancestor was thinking, feeling, learning. We have almost nothing written from previous generations in my family. I found some weather notes and sketches of inventions in my great-grandfather's checkbook, and those fragments inspired me as a high schooler.

The compound effect includes the stories you collect, the wisdom you document, the legacy you build through daily

choices. Every 3 a.m. morning becomes part of a larger narrative about what's possible when you decide to take control of your time and energy.

The Ultimate Return

After two decades of 3 a.m. mornings, here's what I know for certain: the biggest compound effect isn't physical, financial, or even relational. It's the unshakeable knowledge that you can trust yourself.

When you prove to yourself daily that you'll keep your word (to yourself, first and foremost), you develop an inner confidence that can't be borrowed, bought, or faked. You stop looking for external validation because you've built internal integrity.

This doesn't mean perfection or the absence of mistakes. I still have goals I'm inconsistent with, areas where I fall short of my own standards. But the foundation is unbreakable. The discipline anchor is set.

Every morning at 3 a.m., I get another chance to deposit into that compound account, not just for immediate benefits, but for the person I'm becoming and the legacy I'm building.

The Exponential Effect

Here's what most people miss about compound interest: it starts slow, then explodes. The first few years of getting up early might give you slightly better fitness, a little more productivity, marginally improved mood.

But year ten? Year fifteen? Year twenty? That's when the magic happens. When the habits you've built become the foundation for everything else. When the discipline you've

developed in one area automatically transfers to others. When the character you've forged becomes the lens through which you see every challenge.

At twenty years, I'm not just reaping the benefits of early mornings. I'm harvesting the results of becoming the kind of person who keeps his word to himself. Who doesn't negotiate with comfort? Who understands that small, consistent actions create massive, lasting change?

That person can take on any challenge because he's proven to himself, thousands of times over, that he'll show up and do the work regardless of how he feels.

Finding Your Time

The compound effect of twenty years is powerful. But it's not the end. It's the foundation for everything that comes next. Because once you've proven to yourself that discipline works, that consistency pays off, that character compounds over time, a new question emerges:

What if everyone had their own version of 3 a.m.? What if the discipline you've built and the example you've set could help others find their own path to transformation?

That's when you discover that the greatest compound effect isn't what discipline does for you. It's what it does for others through the example you set, the standards you hold, and the proof you provide that this kind of life is possible.

Because the real power of compound discipline isn't personal. It's generational and purposeful.

CHAPTER 19

Your 3 a.m.

The Principle, Not the Hour

Not everyone can do 3 a.m. And honestly, not everyone should.

But everyone has a 3 a.m.: that non-negotiable time carved out for yourself, where you do the thing that matters most before life barges in with its noise, demands, and distractions.

For me, it's been the early mornings for decades. But for you, maybe it's not 3 a.m. Maybe it's 5 a.m. before the kids roll out of bed. Maybe it's your lunch break in your car with a book or notebook. Maybe it's after the night shift, when everyone else is winding down but you're winding up.

The actual time on the clock doesn't matter. The principle does. The discipline does. The choice does.

At the end of the day, your 3 a.m. comes down to one decision: Will you get up and do it, or won't you?

Why You're Doing This

If you don't know your why, you'll quit. Every single time.

When I sat down to write my first book, people asked how I had time with kids, a gym, and a full schedule. The truth is simple: I made time. I wrote on weekends at 3 a.m. while the house was dark, not because I loved typing in silence, but because I wanted my kids to know their dad. I wanted to leave a legacy of words that would outlast me.

That was my why. Yours doesn't need to look like mine. But you'd better have one, because otherwise discipline becomes punishment instead of freedom.

Your why might be wanting to model consistency for your children. Or proving to yourself that you can stick to something. Or creating space for the dreams you've been too busy to pursue. Or simply wanting to feel like you own your day instead of your day owning you.

Whatever it is, write it down. Keep it somewhere you can see it when the alarm goes off and everything in your body screams to stay comfortable.

It's Not About the Time

You don't need to copy me. You don't need to copy Jocko Willink snapping photos of his watch at 4:30 a.m. That's his discipline anchor. You need to build your own.

For a college student, their 3 a.m. might actually be 6 a.m. I get it: night owls exist, and college schedules are different. But here's my issue with the current generation: schedules have gotten soft. Spring break trips, "recovery summers," sleeping until 11 a.m. because you "work so hard at school."

We're raising kids who can't cope with life because every obstacle gets removed from their path. The anxiety, depression, and suicide rates scream at us that young people need purpose, not more comfort.

For a college student, your 3 a.m. might simply be choosing to get up, move, and do something meaningful instead of scrolling TikTok until your brain rots.

For working parents, your 3 a.m. might be 5 a.m. before the kids wake up at 6:30. That single hour is gold. You can move, pray, journal, stretch, or just drink coffee in peace. You can fill your tank before your family drains it.

For shift workers, your 3 a.m. might literally be 2 p.m., right before heading to work. The clock doesn't matter, only that it's consistent.

For retirees, this principle is even more urgent. I've watched too many people die within three years of retirement because they lost purpose. If you don't find your 3 a.m. (a reason to get up, a rhythm, an anchor), you'll drift into nothing.

Finding Your Anchor

If you're not sure what your 3 a.m. should be, start asking yourself some questions:

What did you dream about as a kid before adults told you to be "realistic"? What makes you feel most like yourself? What would you do even if nobody ever knew you were doing it?

For me, I always dreamed about technology and creating things, but thought I was too dumb for it. Now I'm building nutrition apps and writing books about things I once thought were out of reach.

Maybe your dream is simpler. Maybe it's finally putting together that family photo album. Maybe it's learning three chords on the guitar that's been gathering dust. Maybe it's reading the Bible cover to cover, or journaling your story so your grandkids know who you really were.

Your 3 a.m. isn't about fixing the dishwasher or doing chores. It's about giving space to the things you've always said you wanted to do but never had time for.

The Test Questions

How do you know you've found your real 3 a.m.? Here's the test I use:

Question 1: If I did this every day for a year, would my life be different? When I started writing at 3 a.m., I had no idea it would turn into books and a legacy for my kids. But I knew it would move me closer to the man I wanted to be.

Question 2: Can I do this no matter the mood, weather, or chaos of life? Training at 3 a.m. in Wisconsin winter when it's negative ten degrees is a pretty good filter. If I can bundle up and get out the door then, I can do it no matter what.

Question 3: Does this make me feel like the person I want to be? Lifting weights didn't just make me stronger. It made me a man who keeps promises to himself.

Question 4: Would I do this even if nobody knew about it? This one stings because we live in a culture where if it's not posted, it didn't happen. But your real 3 a.m. is the thing you'd do even if no one clapped, even if it never got you a single "like."

If you can answer yes to those questions, you've found it.

Common Obstacles

The excuses will show up. They always do.

"I'm not a morning person." Good. Then don't be. I don't care if your 3 a.m. is 10 p.m. What matters is that you carve out sacred time for yourself. Some of the best writers in history wrote at night after their families went to bed.

"I don't have time." Every time someone says this, I want to grab their phone and open their screen-time report. You have time. You just don't like what the math says when you see four hours of scrolling, endless Netflix, or nights out drinking.

"I don't know what to do." Then start with curiosity. When I first started experimenting with programming, I had no idea it would lead to building apps. But one YouTube tutorial led to another, and now I'm designing systems I once thought were impossible.

"I can't be consistent." Then don't try to be a superhero. Start with two days a week. Nail those. Once they're automatic, add a third. That's how momentum works: you stack bricks until one day you look back and realize you've built a wall.

Building Your System

The system doesn't need to be complicated. In fact, the simpler the better.

When I started journaling, I committed to ten minutes. Not an hour. Not three pages. Just ten minutes. Because it was small, I stuck with it.

Preparation is everything. Lay out clothes the night before. Put shoes by the door. Have your Bible, notebook, or equipment ready so there's no decision fatigue when the alarm goes off.

Expect disruptions. Kids get sick, cars break down, storms hit. Don't use that as a reason to quit. Have a backup version of your 3 a.m.: a shorter workout, a five-minute prayer, a quick paragraph in your journal.

Track effort, not perfection. If you're showing up 80% of the time, you're doing better than 99% of the world. Consistency beats intensity every time.

The Daily Practice

Here's what your 3 a.m. might look like in practice:

The Student's 3 a.m.: 6 a.m. study session with coffee and no phone. Thirty minutes of reading for personal growth, not just assignments. Building the discipline that will carry you through your career.

The Parent's 3 a.m.: 5 a.m. movement and coffee before chaos. Twenty minutes of stretching, journaling, or just sitting in silence. Filling your tank so you can pour into your family.

The Professional's 3 a.m.: Lunch break in your car with an audiobook. Fifteen minutes of walking instead of scrolling. Using your commute for learning instead of complaining.

The Retiree's 3 a.m.: 7 a.m. woodworking, gardening, or writing letters to grandkids. Something that creates instead of consumes. Purpose that doesn't depend on a paycheck.

The specifics don't matter. What matters is that it's yours, it's consistent, and it serves the person you're becoming.

Start Where You Are

You don't need perfect conditions to begin. You don't need a home gym, a writing desk, or ideal circumstances. You just need to start with what you have, where you are.

My first "gym" was a basement with a universal machine. My first book was written on weekend mornings while feeding babies. My discipline was built one small choice at a time, not through some dramatic transformation.

Your 3 a.m. doesn't need to impress anyone. It just needs to serve you. Start with five minutes if that's all you have. Start with a walk around the block if that's all you can manage. Start with a single page in a journal if writing feels overwhelming.

The goal isn't to become someone else overnight. It's to become slightly more yourself every day.

Your Challenge

By the end of this week, I want you to define your 3 a.m. Not mine. Yours.

Name it. Write it down. Then commit to showing up for 30 days. Not perfectly, not impressively: just consistently.

Set your alarm fifteen minutes earlier than usual. Use that time for something that matters to you, not something that's urgent for someone else. Do it when you don't feel like it. Do it when you're tired. Do it when you have excuses.

Because here's the truth: your 3 a.m. isn't about proving anything to anyone else. It's about proving something to yourself. It's proving that your life is worth carving time out for, that your dreams are worth more than your distractions, that your discipline can build the person you've always wanted to become.

The Final Dawn

Once you find your 3 a.m. and start showing up for it consistently, something shifts. You stop being someone who's trying to be disciplined and become someone who simply is disciplined. You stop hoping for change and start creating it.

But that's just the beginning. Because the real power of discipline isn't what it does for you in isolation. It's what it does for everyone whose life intersects with yours. Your spouse, your kids, your coworkers, your community.

The discipline you build in private becomes the strength others lean on in public. The character you forge in the dark becomes the light others follow toward their own transformation.

Your 3 a.m. isn't just personal development. It's the foundation for generational change. And once you understand that truth (once you realize that your small, daily choices echo through eternity), everything changes.

Your 3 a.m. is waiting. The only question left is: will you show up for it?

CHAPTER 20

The Dawn

Beyond Personal

When the alarm clock goes off tomorrow morning, it's not just about you anymore.

Discipline doesn't stop at self-improvement. It multiplies through everyone who watches, listens, and learns from you. That's the real compound effect.

You think it's just training, or journaling, or waking up early. But your kids are watching. Your coworkers are noticing. Your clients, neighbors, and friends feel it. People won't always understand why you do what you do in the dark. They'll call it talent, luck, or obsession. They won't see the years of reps, the thousands of small choices, the nights you said no to comfort and yes to character.

And that's okay. You don't need them to understand. You're not building for applause. You're building for legacy.

I think of Joe "Skittles" Skitz, one of my first clients. Fifty years old, overweight, depressed, going through a divorce, stuck in a high-stress job as a train engineer. Rock bottom

doesn't begin to describe where he was when he walked into my gym.

The first time he tried to get up from a bench press, he rolled off the side and landed on his hands and knees. But instead of quitting, he picked himself up: one step, one rep, one choice at a time.

He stuck with it. Day after day. Dropped 100 pounds in a year, never once "cheating" on the nutrition plan I gave him. That discipline carried him all the way to a powerlifting meet, and then to a bodybuilding stage: a dream he'd carried since childhood but never believed he could achieve.

That's the ripple effect of discipline. It doesn't just transform a body. It saves a life. And that saved life goes on to inspire others: his coworkers, his family, strangers who see his transformation and think, "If he can do it, maybe I can too."

The Dawn Decision

Every new day is a dawn. A clean slate. A chance to choose.

Discipline isn't complicated. It's a decision. One. That's it. The alarm goes off. Do you sit up, put your feet on the floor, and move? Or do you roll over, hit snooze, and let the day own you before you even start?

It doesn't matter how motivated you feel. It doesn't matter what the weather is, how tired you are, or what excuse is screaming in your head. It's one decision. And that decision sets the tone for everything that follows.

Here's the trick: you don't need to decide 100 times. You just need to decide once, and then keep proving that first decision true. Wake up tomorrow. Do the thing. Repeat.

Will you stumble? Of course. Life will throw family stress, financial pressure, injuries, and setbacks at you. I've lived it all. But discipline is the anchor that keeps you steady. And sometimes discipline isn't about pushing harder. It's about making the wise choice to rest, recharge, and come back stronger.

The Generational Impact

Someday, your grandkids won't inherit your car, your bank account, or your phone. Those things fade, break, disappear. What they *will* inherit is the example of how you lived.

I think about this every time I journal. I don't just write for myself. I write because someday, maybe fifty or a hundred years from now, my great-grandkids might find my notebooks. They'll see what I was thinking, fighting for, how I pushed through adversity. They'll know that discipline runs in their blood.

Brooklyn understands this already at six years old. When she asks, "Is this morning for you, and for me is it night?" she's learning that some people get up early to take care of business. That success isn't accidental. That the adults in her life choose discipline over comfort, and that choice creates the stability she lives in.

She's watching me make my bed every morning, prep meals with intention, treat my body like it matters. She's learning that discipline isn't punishment. It's self-respect in action. And someday, when life gets hard for her, she'll remember that she comes from people who don't quit when things get difficult.

That's legacy. That's what you're really building. Not just muscle or business success or personal achievement. You're building a foundation that outlives you.

From Darkness to Dawn

Six months later, Mike walked into my gym with something I hadn't seen in his face for over a year: quiet determination.

The divorce was still proceeding. The financial stress remained. His life had been turned upside down in every measurable way. But something fundamental had shifted. He'd been showing up: every session, on time, focused. The weight was coming off steadily. More importantly, the man I'd watched grow from sixteen to thirty-six was emerging again.

"I realized something," he told me between sets. "My boys are watching everything. They're seeing how their dad handles the worst time of his life. I can either show them what it looks like to give up, or I can show them what it looks like to persevere."

That's when I understood what I was really witnessing. Not just a physical transformation, but a father choosing to become someone his children could be proud of even when (especially when) everything was falling apart.

Mike was using the discipline anchor he'd built twenty years earlier to navigate the storm. The habits we'd forged when he was a teenager became the foundation he stood on when his adult life crumbled. Every morning he chose to get up and train was a vote for the kind of father he wanted to be.

The joy was returning to his eyes. Not because his circumstances had improved, but because he'd remembered who he was underneath the crisis. Someone who doesn't quit. Someone who fights back. Someone who shows up for the people who matter most.

I watched him finish his last set and saw something beautiful: a man transforming his darkest hour into his children's greatest lesson about resilience. The discipline he was rebuilding wasn't just changing his body. It was modeling for his boys that when life knocks you down, you don't stay down.

That's the real power of discipline. It doesn't prevent darkness from coming. But it teaches you how to carry your own light through whatever darkness arrives. And sometimes, that light becomes a beacon for others, especially the small ones watching from the sidelines, learning what's possible when someone refuses to quit.

Watching Mike rebuild reminded me why this work matters. Why getting up at 3 a.m. matters. Why keeping promises to yourself matters. Not just for you, but for everyone whose life your discipline touches. Your children, your community, the next generation who needs proof that comeback is always possible.

The dawn always comes. But only for those who refuse to stay in the dark.

Reclaim Your Morning, Reclaim Yourself

You've been putting yourself last. Work gets the first call, kids get the first energy, responsibilities get the first hours. By the time you think about *you*, the day is already gone.

That stops now.

If you want to rediscover yourself (the kid who used to dream big, the competitor who refused to quit, the person who believed there was more to life), you're going to have to fight for it. And the fight starts in the morning.

Set your alarm earlier. Not because it's easy. Not because you "have time." But because this is the one block of the day no one can steal from you. Before the texts, before the kids, before the chaos: it's just you.

No excuses. No scrolling. No hiding.

Read. Write. Train. Pray. Build something. Chase the dream you've been too busy to admit you still want. Those first minutes of the day are yours, and yours alone. Protect them like your life depends on it, because your future does.

Stop saying "someday." Stop saying "later." You've been saying that for years.

Tomorrow morning is your shot. Take it.

When You Lead Others Follow

Here's what happens when you start living with discipline: other people notice. Not because you're preaching or posting about it, but because there's something different about someone who's taken control of their life.

Your spouse sees you getting up early and starts wondering if they could do the same. Your kids watch you keep your word to yourself and learn what integrity actually looks like. Your coworkers notice your consistency and energy, and some of them start asking questions.

You become proof that this kind of life is possible. Not through perfection, everyone will see your struggles too, but through persistence. Through the daily choice to show up for yourself even when it's hard.

That's leadership. Not a title or a position, but influence earned through example. When you lead yourself well, others naturally want to follow.

I see this happen in my gym constantly. One person transforms their life, and suddenly their spouse wants to train. Their kids start asking about nutrition. Their friends want to know what changed. The ripple effect spreads outward in ways you can't predict or control.

But it starts with one person deciding they're worth the effort. One person choosing to get up early. One person refusing to accept that "this is just how I am."

The Compound Beyond You

The mathematics of discipline aren't just personal. They're exponential. When you change, everyone in your sphere of influence gets affected. Your transformation gives others permission to transform. Your discipline becomes their proof that change is possible.

Think about it: if you help one person find their discipline, and they help one person, and so on, how many lives get changed over a generation? How many families avoid divorce because someone learned to take care of themselves first? How many kids grow up in homes where discipline is modeled instead of just demanded?

This isn't theory. I've watched it happen. The businessman who started training with me because his son needed help getting in shape for football. The mother who found her strength again and became an example for her daughters. The teenager who learned discipline in my gym and carried it into his marriage, his career, his parenting.

Each transformation creates more transformations. Each person who refuses to quit becomes proof for someone else that quitting isn't the only option.

Your Dawn Is Waiting

So here we are. Twenty chapters. Thousands of words. All leading to this moment when you have to choose: Will you close this book and go back to your old life, or will you use it as the foundation for something new?

The alarm will go off tomorrow morning. It always does. The question is: who will answer it?

Will it be the person who hits snooze and starts the day behind, reactive, at the mercy of whatever happens? Or will it be the person who gets up, takes control, and proves once again that they're someone who keeps their word to themselves?

The choice is yours. It's always been yours.

But understand this: that choice doesn't just affect you. It affects your kids, who are learning what's possible by watching what you do. It affects your spouse, who's wondering if they married someone who gives up or someone who fights through. It affects every person whose life intersects with yours, consciously or unconsciously.

You have more power than you realize. Not power over others, but power over yourself. And when you exercise that power consistently (when you prove day after day that you're someone who can be counted on to do the hard thing), you become a force for good in a world that desperately needs people who don't quit.

The Dawn Promise

Here's my promise to you: if you commit to finding your 3 a.m. and showing up for it consistently, your life will change. Not might change. Will change.

Maybe not in the ways you expect. Maybe not as quickly as you want. But it will change because *you* will change. And when you change, everything around you shifts to accommodate the new person you've become.

The discipline you build in the dark will light up everything else. The character you forge in private will serve you in public. The promises you keep to yourself will become the foundation for every other relationship in your life.

But this only works if you work it. The principles in this book aren't magic. They're mathematics. Consistent action over time creates predictable results. But you have to do the action every day, especially when you don't feel like it.

One Last Thing

As you close this book and head toward tomorrow morning's alarm, remember this: you're not just changing your life. You're changing your family line. You're becoming an ancestor that future generations will be proud to descend from.

Years from now, when your grandkids ask about you, what story will get told? Will they hear about someone who made excuses and gave up when things got hard? Or will they hear about someone who got up every morning and did the work, who sacrificed for their family and proved what character really looks like?

That story gets written one morning at a time. One choice at a time. One dawn at a time.

Your alarm is set. Your opportunity is waiting. The only question left is: What kind of ancestor do you want to be?

The dawn is yours. Don't waste it.

Rise.

"The most important conversation you have each day is the one you have with yourself in the first hour you're awake. Make it count."

– Glen Rogers

THE END